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From Planning to Action: Municipal Crisis Communication and Public Preparedness in Norrköping Municipality

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Abstract

In recent years, crisis preparedness has become a central societal issue, shaped by increasing geopolitical tensions, societal vulnerabilities and security challenges. This thesis examines the relationship between municipal crisis communication and residents' preparedness. In Sweden, municipalities play a central role in planning and communicating preparedness, yet previous research highlights a gap between institutional intentions and individuals' preparedness. The aim of this study is to contribute to research on the gap between institutional and individual preparedness by analysing how crisis and war preparedness is planned and communicated by Norrköping municipality and how this aligns with residents' perceived preparedness and intended actions in crisis scenarios. The study applies a mixed-methods case study design, combining document analysis, survey data and semi-structured interviews to capture institutional and individual perspectives. It draws on theories of crisis communication, risk perception and governance.

The findings show that preparedness is framed institutionally through expectations of individual responsibility and access to information. However, residents' preparedness is uneven and influenced by factors such as risk perception, trust and everyday constraints. A key result is the awareness-action gap, where residents often understand preparedness information but do not translate it into concrete measures. Instead, intended actions are characterised by improvisation and reliance on infrastructure and actors. The study concludes that preparedness cannot be understood as a linear process from planning to action. Instead, it is shaped by the interaction between institutional communication and individual interpretation. The findings highlight the need for more locally adapted and participatory communication strategies to strengthen societal resilience.

Keywords: Civil preparedness, Municipal planning, Preparedness communication, Risk perception & Societal resilience

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1. Introduction

In recent years, crisis preparedness has moved from being a secondary concern to becoming a central societal issue (European Commission, 2025). Across Europe and globally, increasing geopolitical tensions such as the war in Ukraine, cyber threats and disruptions to critical infrastructure have exposed vulnerabilities in modern societies (European External Action Service, 2024, p. 8 & 14). Events such as large-scale power outages, failures in digital communication systems and disruptions to supply chains demonstrate how quickly everyday life can be disrupted (World Economic Forum, 2023, p. 69 & 71). In highly interconnected and infrastructure-dependent societies, even temporary disruptions can have major effects on access to essential services such as food, water, communication and transportation (Kaneberg, 2018, p. 25 & 48). At the same time, Myndigheten för samhällsskydd och beredskap (MSB) highlights that growing awareness of security threats and future crises raises concerns about large-scale disruptions, including the possibility of war and emphasises the need for both institutional preparedness and individual capacity (MSB, 2024, p. 3). In the Swedish context, these changes in the security environment have translated into concrete changes in crisis and war preparedness, particularly following war in Europe and Sweden's membership in NATO. As a result, there are increasing expectations on civil preparedness, where not only authorities but also residents are expected to be able to act and contribute in situations of crisis (Heidenfors Armblad, 2023, p. 6-7).

Within this context, municipalities play a central role, as they are key actors in Sweden's crisis management system, responsible for planning, coordinating and communicating preparedness to residents (Norrköpings kommun, 2024, p. 3-4). Preparedness communication is therefore a crucial link between institutional planning and individual action (MSB, 2022, p. 13 & 17). However, previous research suggests that the existence of preparedness plans and the provision of information do not necessarily lead to preparedness in practice (Levac et al., 2012, p. 730). Instead, a recurring challenge is the differences between institutional intentions and residents' actual preparedness (Kaneberg, 2018, p. 22 & 49). Preparedness is not only a matter of technical planning or policy design, but also of how information is understood, interpreted and acted upon by residents in everyday life. Research shows that individuals do not base their responses to risk solely on technical information. Perceptions of risk are shaped by factors such as trust, social context and perceived control (Slovic, 2000, p. 233-234). In addition, preparedness behaviour is influenced by factors such as motivation, attitudes and self-efficacy, which affect whether individuals translate knowledge into action (Chen et al., 2019, p. 5 & 7).

Against this background, this study examines how municipal crisis and war preparedness is planned and communicated and how this aligns with residents' perceived preparedness and intended actions. By focusing on Norrköping municipality as a case, the study analyses how preparedness is framed institutionally, how residents interpret this information and how they describe their intended actions in different crisis scenarios. By addressing the gap between institutional intentions and residents' preparedness, this study contributes to a deeper understanding of how preparedness is translated from planning into practice. In doing so, it highlights the importance of not only improving planning and communication, but also understanding how preparedness is shaped in everyday life within infrastructure-dependent urban societies.

1.1 Norrköping Municipality

Norrköping municipality is selected as the empirical case for this study due to its relevance for examining municipal crisis and war preparedness within a Swedish urban context. With approximately 145,000 inhabitants, Norrköping is one of Sweden's larger municipalities in terms of population (Norrköpings kommun, 2026a). The municipality includes both densely populated urban areas and surrounding semi-urban and rural districts (Norrköpings

kommun, 2026a). Like all Swedish municipalities, Norrköping operates within the national framework for local governance and carries legal responsibility for civil protection, crisis preparedness and civil defence (Norrköpings kommun, n.d.-a). The municipality is responsible for planning, coordinating and communicating preparedness and crisis-related information to residents, in accordance with its crisis management plan and geographical area responsibility (Norrköpings kommun, 2024, p. 3-4). This makes Norrköping a relevant case for analysing how institutional preparedness is translated into public communication and individual preparedness.

Norrköping, like other Swedish municipalities, is dependent on critical infrastructure systems such as electricity, digital communication networks and retail supply chains. This dependence creates structural vulnerability in situations involving disruption (Kaneberg, 2018, p. 25 & 48). National preparedness information from MSB further emphasises that modern society's reliance on connected technical systems increases vulnerability, particularly in situations involving power outages, cyber incidents or disruptions to supply chains (MSB, 2024). This type of infrastructure dependence is characteristic of many modern urban municipalities and is therefore relevant for examining residents' preparedness and intended actions.

From a practical perspective, Norrköping was selected as it allows for an in-depth analysis of municipal preparedness planning and communication. The case study design enables a detailed examination of how preparedness is framed institutionally and how residents interpret and respond to this information, which would be difficult to achieve in a broader comparative study. Norrköping can also be understood as broadly representative of a mid-sized Swedish municipality, making it analytically relevant for understanding preparedness challenges across similar urban contexts. Taken together, Norrköping is selected as a relevant case for examining how preparedness is translated from institutional planning into individual action.

1.2 Background

Recent security developments have renewed attention to preparedness. Crisis preparedness includes risks such as war, electricity disruptions, cyber incidents, extreme weather and disruptions to critical infrastructure (Kaneberg, 2018, p. 25-26). In the Swedish context, crisis preparedness has re-emerged as a central societal concern in recent years, driven by changes in the security situation. As a result of Russia's invasion of Ukraine and Sweden's accession to NATO, increased demands have been placed on the civilian part of national preparedness, which is considered insufficient (Heidenfors Armblad, 2023, p. 2 & 6). Civil defence today is not limited to military preparedness, but also includes the capacity of residents to act under conditions of severe disruption, requiring long-term planning already in peacetime (Heidenfors Armblad, 2023, p. 6-7). Despite political attention, research indicates that crisis preparedness systems in Sweden remain not fully integrated particularly at the local level. Planning responsibilities are distributed across multiple actors and levels and preparedness plans often lack clear mechanisms for implementation and coordination (Kaneberg, 2018, p. 107-108). While municipalities play a central role in crisis management and public communication the translation of plans and strategies into practical preparedness remains a challenge (Kaneberg, 2018, p. 49 & 53).

Previous research further demonstrates that the existence of preparedness plans and information does not necessarily result in individuals understanding the information or acting upon it in practice. Lavelle (2012) identifies the difference between hazards as potential threats and disasters as events that overwhelm a community's capacity to respond, emphasising that disasters are shaped not only by external events but by levels of preparedness at both institutional and household levels (Lavelle, 2012, p. 1-2). Although public authorities are responsible for providing and communicating preparedness information, individuals and households are often insufficiently prepared. This creates

challenges in translating institutional intentions into actual preparedness outcomes (Kaneberg, 2018, p. 22 & 71). This issue is particularly critical from a strategic urban and regional planning perspective. Effective preparedness depends not only on policies and communication strategies, but on how residents understand information and translate it into action.

This problem is important to address as societal resilience is closely linked to residents' ability to prepare for and act during disruptions (Levac et al., 2012, p. 728). Situations involving warning signals combined with power and digital communication disruptions highlight potential gaps between communicated preparedness and residents' capacity to act, particularly in infrastructure-dependent societies (Kaneberg, 2018, p. 48). Examining municipal planning and communication alongside residents' scenario-based responses enables an analysis of how preparedness is translated from planning into action at the local level, as planning plays a central role in structuring how actors respond in crisis situations (Kaneberg, 2018, p. 50-51).

1.3 Problem Statement

Despite renewed political attention and strengthened national frameworks for civil preparedness, differences remain between institutional planning and residents' practical preparedness. Municipalities are formally responsible for planning, coordinating and communicating crisis preparedness, yet previous research shows that the existence of preparedness plans and information does not automatically result in preparedness (Kaneberg, 2018, p. 49 & 71).

In the Swedish context, crisis preparedness today covers a broad range of risks including disruptions to electricity supply, cyber incidents, extreme weather events and in more severe scenarios, war. Although war is one possible crisis scenario, it is not the main focus of current preparedness policies. Instead, preparedness is framed as an ongoing societal responsibility aimed at strengthening resilience across multiple types of disruptions (Heidenfors Armblad, 2023, p. 6-7). This broader crisis perspective raises questions about how residents understand, interpret and act upon preparedness information in everyday life. This is particularly relevant in urban contexts, where residents are highly dependent on infrastructure systems, digital communication networks and retail supply chains. Disruptions to systems such as electricity, payment systems or transport can rapidly limit access to food, water and information. Despite this structural vulnerability, it remains unclear whether residents in Norrköping perceive such risks as personally relevant or whether they translate communicated preparedness guidance into concrete action.

Institutional actors often assume that providing clear and accessible information is sufficient to enable residents to recognise risks and take appropriate action. According to Coombs (2019), communication during the pre-crisis phase is intended to clarify expectations, reduce uncertainty and prepare stakeholders before disruption occurs (Coombs, 2019, p. 10-11). However, effective preparedness communication depends not only on how clear information is communicated, but also on how it is interpreted. Individuals do not assess risks based only on expert information, instead their judgments are influenced by factors such as perceived control, familiarity and trust in authorities (Slovic, 2000, p. 233-234). Preparedness governance often relies on a structured, expert-driven and top-down logic, creating tensions between institutional planning and residents' lived experiences (Albrechts & Balducci, 2013, p. 18 & 20). Residents' responses however are shaped by lived experience, emotional evaluation and social context (Slovic, 2000, p. 404-405). Research on strategic planning shows ongoing tensions between top-down governance and more inclusive, participatory approaches (Albrechts & Balducci, 2013, p. 24). When risks are perceived as distant, unlikely or primarily managed by public authorities, individuals may be less likely to assume personal responsibility for preparedness (Slovic, 2000, p. 394-395).

From a governance perspective, this also raises questions about how preparedness is organised. Existing approaches often rely on hierarchical planning structures and information provision, while research on urban transformative capacity emphasises the importance of inclusive governance, participation and collaboration across actors and levels (Wolfram, 2016, p. 126-127). This suggests a potential limitation in current preparedness approaches, where residents are expected to act, while their involvement in shaping preparedness processes may be limited. The main problem addressed in this thesis is therefore not the lack of preparedness planning, but potential differences between institutional assumptions and residents' interpretations and actions. There is therefore a need to examine how crisis preparedness is communicated at the municipal level, how residents understand and respond to this information and why communicated preparedness does not always translate into actual preparedness. This study addresses this gap by analysing both municipal communication and residents' perceived preparedness and intended actions in an urban context.

1.4 Aim

The aim of this thesis is to examine how Norrköping municipality plans and communicates crisis and war preparedness. The study further examines how residents perceive and interpret preparedness communication in relation to their own preparedness and intended actions in crisis scenarios.

1.5 Research Questions

1.5.1 Main research question

How does municipal planning and communication of crisis and war preparedness align with residents' perceived preparedness and intended actions in crisis scenarios?

1.5.2 Sub-questions

- How does Norrköping municipality plan and communicate crisis and war preparedness to residents?

- How do residents perceive their preparedness and awareness of crisis and war preparedness?

- How do residents describe their intended actions in response to different crisis scenarios and how do these relate to their perceived preparedness?

- What gaps can be identified between institutional expectations and residents' perceived preparedness and intended actions?

1.6 Relevance & Contribution

This study contributes to research on crisis and war preparedness by linking institutional planning and communication with residents' perceived preparedness and intended actions in a concrete local context. Within strategic urban and regional planning, this thesis treats municipal preparedness communication as a planning instrument that shapes implementation capacity and everyday resilience in urban settings that depend on critical infrastructure. Preparedness planning has been shown to structure coordination and response capacity across different planning levels (Kaneberg, 2018, p. 50-51). While previous research has examined civil preparedness at system and policy levels such as Kaneberg (2018) and Heidenfors Armblad (2023), fewer studies focus on how preparedness communication is understood and applied by residents in everyday contexts. By focusing on how municipal preparedness communication is interpreted and translated into intended action at the individual level, the study contributes to previous research on the relationship between institutional planning intentions and practical preparedness outcomes (Lavelle, 2012, p. 9-10). The use of scenario-based questions enables insight into preparedness under

constrained conditions, beyond self-reported awareness.

Empirically, the study contributes knowledge on crisis and war preparedness in a Swedish municipal context at a time of security concerns. The findings may inform future communication strategies by highlighting how institutional assumptions do not always align with residents' preparedness. From a strategic urban and regional planning perspective, the study explores whether integrated communication, planning and resident engagement contribute to societal resilience and how residents apply the communicated preparedness information. The study also addresses questions of vulnerability and resilience in urban settings, where residents are highly dependent on access to essential supplies and digital infrastructure.

2. Literature Review

This chapter reviews previous research on civil preparedness, with a focus on how preparedness is shaped by both institutional and individual factors. It begins by examining preparedness in modern societies and the challenges of governance and infrastructure. It then explores the relationship between planning and preparedness, followed by research on individual preparedness and behaviour. The final section brings these perspectives together and identifies a gap in existing research.

2.1 Civil preparedness in complex societies

Civil preparedness in modern societies depends on how infrastructure, governance and different actors interact across levels. In the Swedish context, Kaneberg (2018) writes that preparedness is embedded in complex networks of critical infrastructure and supply chains, where disruptions in one sector may spread to others (Kaneberg, 2018, p. 17-18). This is especially evident in modern, highly efficient societies, where limited backup systems increase vulnerability to disruptions spreading across sectors (Kaneberg, 2018, p. 22-23). This perspective is further supported by research showing that disasters are not only caused by external hazards, but are also shaped by social, political and economic conditions that influence how vulnerable different groups and systems are to risk (Tierney, 2014, p. 5-6). At the same time preparedness is based on an all-hazards approach where different risks such as cyber incidents, infrastructure disruptions and war are addressed within the same planning framework (Kaneberg, 2018, p. 25). This perspective is reinforced by research on risk governance, which shows that modern risks are complex, uncertain and interconnected, requiring coordination between multiple public and private actors rather than relying on traditional hierarchical control (Renn, 2008, p. 8-9).

However, this complexity is not only technical but also institutional. Heidenfors Armblad (2023) emphasises that Swedish civil preparedness is highly dependent on public-private collaboration, as critical infrastructure systems are owned or operated by private actors (Heidenfors Armblad, 2023, p. 6-7). This creates governance challenges, as collaboration is often limited by unclear legal frameworks, divided responsibilities and conflicting interests between public preparedness goals and private economic priorities (Heidenfors Armblad, 2023, p. 8-9). Similarly, Kaneberg (2018) highlights gaps across governance levels and preparedness structures, which make coordination and long-term resilience more difficult to achieve (Kaneberg, 2018, p. 5-6).

Taken together, these studies show that preparedness is shaped by both infrastructure systems and governance challenges. While Kaneberg (2018) focuses on how connections between different systems can make society more vulnerable to disruptions, Heidenfors Armblad (2023) shows how rules, responsibilities and organisation influence how well these risks can be managed. The two perspectives are therefore complementary, one explains why disruptions are difficult to manage, while the other explains why coordination is difficult to achieve. However, while these perspectives provide important insights into vulnerability and governance challenges, they say less about how these conditions are translated into everyday preparedness practices at the local level. This means that civil preparedness can be understood as a governance challenge that depends on coordination, trust and clear responsibilities across multiple actors and levels (Heidenfors Armblad, 2023, p. 24-25). Effective preparedness therefore requires not only formal plans, but also ongoing coordination, shared information and clearly defined roles across actors and governance levels. Cultural approaches to risk suggest that trying to eliminate uncertainty through increasing control can itself create vulnerability. Instead, resilient systems depend on flexibility, diversity and the ability to adapt, rather than assuming that all risks can be predicted in advance (Douglas & Wildavsky, 1983, p. 196-197).

2.2 The gap between planning and preparedness

Although preparedness is often addressed through planning and policy frameworks, formal plans do not always translate into preparedness in practice (Kaneberg, 2018, p. 108). Kaneberg (2018) writes that preparedness systems in Sweden remain insufficiently integrated, particularly at the local level where responsibilities are distributed across multiple actors and sectors (Kaneberg, 2018, p. 21-22). While formal plans and structures exist, they often lack clear ways to be implemented, coordinated and adapted to changing conditions (Kaneberg, 2018, p. 52-53). Similar challenges are also highlighted in disaster research, which shows that measures to reduce risk are often well known but still difficult to implement due to institutional constraints, conflicting interests and limited political support for long-term change (Tierney, 2014, p. 6). Effective preparedness depends on the ability to notice early warning signs, avoid oversimplifying complex situations and adapt before small problems develop into larger crises (Weick & Sutcliffe, 2015, p. 2). Preparedness is not a fixed result of planning, but an ongoing process requiring coordination and engagement.

2.2.1 Preparedness planning and communication

Previous research further shows that preparedness communication often follows hierarchical, top-down communication channels, which do not necessarily result in meaningful engagement or behavioural change (Lavelle, 2012, p. 19-20). One-way information is often insufficient to influence behaviour, as effective preparedness requires two-way communication, dialogue and engagement with local communities rather than simply sharing information (Steelman & McCaffrey, 2012, p. 685-686). Effective preparedness communication also depends on the use of established and trusted communication channels, as preferences for receiving risk information vary across populations and contexts (Tam et al., 2018, p. 7-8). This aligns with research on risk and crisis communication in Europe, which emphasises that one-way communication is often insufficient, while two-way communication enables dialogue, trust and more effective engagement with citizens (Eriksson, 2024, p. 14-15). Similarly, information alone is insufficient to generate preparedness, as knowledge must be complemented by changes in attitudes and behavioural motivation (Ning et al., 2021, p. 5-6). Chen et al. (2019, p. 5) show that individuals often fail to act on preparedness information, not due to lack of access but due to uncertainty, avoidance and low motivation. In addition, studies show that communication is most effective when it is ongoing across the entire disaster cycle and when relationships, trust and shared understanding are built before a crisis occurs, rather than relying solely on communication during the event itself (Steelman & McCaffrey, 2012, p. 700-701).

2.2.2 Individual preparedness and barriers to action

This implementation problem becomes even more evident when examining preparedness at the individual and local levels. Levac et al. (2012) show that preparedness information does not automatically translate into action, as individuals face multiple barriers including lack of time, limited resources and difficulties understanding or applying preparedness guidance (Levac et al., 2012, p. 730-731). Similarly, Kaneberg (2018) notes that preparedness efforts are often prioritised only after crises occur, while proactive engagement remains limited (Kaneberg, 2018, p. 5 & 21). These findings challenge the assumption that preparedness can be achieved through information provision alone and highlight the importance of examining how communication is interpreted and acted upon in practice. This is further explained by the Protective Action Decision Model, which shows that individuals do not act on information directly, but must first receive, interpret and evaluate it in relation to perceived risk, available protective actions and trust in the information source (Lindell & Perry, 2012, p. 616-617). The model also highlights that unclear or inconsistent information may delay action, as individuals tend to seek additional confirmation before responding to a perceived threat (Lindell & Perry, 2012, p. 618).

Research also shows that preparedness is weakened when expert warnings are

ignored and decision-making is too hierarchical, as this reduces the organisation's ability to respond to emerging risks in time (Weick & Sutcliffe, 2015, p. 10-11). Communication is not only about sharing information, but also about helping people understand crisis situations, as leaders need to explain what is happening and provide clear guidance in order to reduce uncertainty and maintain public trust (Boin et al., 2005, p. 559). The knowledge-gap perspective also has important limitations, as providing more expert information alone does not necessarily lead to preparedness behaviour (Eriksson, 2024, p. 15). Many residents prefer clear risk levels and simple guidance during crises, suggesting that preparedness communication is more effective when authorities provide structured, practical and easy-to-understand information (Tam et al., 2018, p. 9-10).

In addition, local authorities often have limited resources and staff, which can make it difficult for them to go beyond simply providing information and instead engage more actively in preparedness work (Lavelle, 2012, p. 23 & 35). Preparedness systems also often struggle to move beyond planning due to organisational constraints and a lack of effective ways to engage people (Lavelle, 2012, p. 8 & 23). This highlights a limitation of planning-based approaches, where preparedness is often treated as simply providing information rather than as a process shaped by how people understand, are motivated by and are able to act on that information in everyday life. Similarly, research highlights that lack of time, resources and clear guidance are key barriers preventing individuals from translating preparedness information into action (Levac et al., 2012, p. 730). However, Chen et al. (2019, p. 5) show that motivational and psychological factors rather than material resources are often more significant barriers to preparedness. Similarly, studies show that lack of time, resources and clear guidance are among the most common barriers preventing individuals from taking preparedness measures (Kohn et al., 2012, p. 228).

2.2.3 Trust and preparedness communication

Trust and credibility further complicate this relationship. Levac et al. (2012) emphasise that access to clear and reliable information is a key factor of preparedness behaviour, as individuals are more likely to act when they understand risks and recommended measures (Levac et al., 2012, p. 730). This aligns with Heidenfors Armblad (2023), who identifies trust and ongoing interaction as central factors for effective collaboration between institutional actors (Heidenfors Armblad, 2023, p. 24-25). Together, these perspectives suggest that preparedness communication is not only a technical process of sharing information, but a relational process shaped by trust, clear roles and perceived responsibility. This is also supported by research showing that trust in authorities depends more on prior interaction, transparency and locally trusted actors than on information alone (Steelman & McCaffrey, 2012, p. 695 & 702).

2.3 Individual preparedness and behaviour

Preparedness is shaped by a combination of behavioural, social and structural factors rather than by awareness alone. Chen et al. (2019, p. 7-8) writes that preparedness is strongly influenced by psychological factors such as perceived self-efficacy and reliance on authorities, which may reduce individuals' willingness to act. Levac et al. (2012) also show that preparedness is shaped by several factors, including self-efficacy, social support and access to resources (Levac et al., 2012, p. 725). For example, households with children are often more prepared, while vulnerable groups such as individuals with disabilities or chronic illness face greater barriers and are often less prepared (Kohn et al., 2012, p. 229). Preparedness can therefore be understood as socially uneven and dependent on everyday conditions rather than only on knowledge. This aligns with research showing that vulnerability to disasters is unevenly distributed and shaped by social, economic and structural conditions, where marginalised groups often face greater risks due to limited resources and weaker support systems (Tierney, 2014, p. 227). Research from Hong Kong also shows that household preparedness is associated with socioeconomic factors such as income and education. Lower-income households tend to be less prepared and therefore may

require more targeted preparedness support (Tam et al., 2018, p. 6 & 8).

2.3.1 Behavioural and motivational factors

These findings challenge the idea that increasing risk awareness leads to preparedness and instead highlight the importance of motivational and social factors in shaping behaviour (Tan et al., 2024, p. 8). Research also shows that preparedness is mainly influenced by factors such as self-efficacy, outcome efficacy, attitudes, social norms and access to information, while risk perception plays a smaller role (Tan et al., 2024, p. 5-6). This pattern can partly be explained by individuals relying on public authorities and seeing crisis management as mainly a public responsibility, which may reduce motivation to prepare themselves (Lavelle, 2012, p. 28 & 30). Similarly, Chen et al. (2019, p. 8) show that many individuals rely on authorities to manage crises, which may reduce personal responsibility and preparedness behaviour. In addition, even when individuals intend to act, practical constraints such as lack of resources, time or access to transportation may prevent people from taking protective actions (Lindell & Perry, 2012, p. 624). This is further reinforced by findings showing that high levels of trust in authorities may reduce individual preparedness by shifting responsibility from individuals to the state (Ning et al., 2021, p. 1).

2.3.2 Social capital and community preparedness

Recent research highlights the importance of social capital and community networks, showing that preparedness is shaped not only by individual factors but also by relationships, trust and local social structures. From this perspective, preparedness also depends on whether people are part of social networks and local communities that support collective action and shared support during crises (Eriksson, 2024, p. 20-21). Similarly, strong social networks and community ties make it more likely that people follow preparedness recommendations and support each other during crises (Norris et al., 2007, p. 138). Local networks and neighbours are often the first to provide help during disasters, showing the importance of social ties for immediate response and recovery (Aldrich & Meyer, 2015, p. 256). In addition, Aldrich and Meyer (2015) describe social capital as consisting of bonding, bridging and linking, which together influence preparedness and response in different ways. Close ties (bonding) provide immediate support during crises, while connections across groups (bridging) and links to institutions (linking) enable access to information, resources and assistance (Aldrich & Meyer, 2015, p. 258-259). However, while these studies identify key behavioural and social factors, they mainly focus on the individual level and do not fully consider how these are shaped by broader institutional and infrastructural conditions. Many people lack emergency supplies and preparedness plans and may not fully understand what preparedness involves, such as how to prepare emergency kits or develop plans (Kohn et al., 2012, p. 226 & 228). Ning et al. (2021) further develop this perspective by showing that preparedness behaviour is more strongly influenced by attitudes and self-efficacy than by risk perception alone (Ning et al., 2021, p. 4-5). In line with this, risk perception alone is not enough to explain preparedness behaviour, as people also consider how effective, practical and costly proactive actions are (Lindell & Perry, 2012, p. 625-626).

2.3.3 Preparedness behaviour and practical limitations

Research also shows that people often perceive themselves as prepared despite lacking essential resources or plans (Kohn et al., 2012, p. 227). This further supports the argument that preparedness is not only shaped by access to information, but also by how communication is experienced, including whether individuals feel involved, informed and able to act based on the information provided (Steelman & McCaffrey, 2012, p. 686). Preparedness efforts are more effective when they address these factors rather than focusing on information (Amberson et al., 2024, p. 2 & 4). However, efforts to improve preparedness such as education, social support and behavioural programmes often have limited or inconsistent effects, with only small improvements in actual preparedness behaviour (Amberson et al., 2024, p. 21-22). Improving preparedness may require a combination of education, behavioural support and social support, rather than relying on information alone

(Amberson et al., 2021, p. 2). These findings show that it is difficult to turn knowledge and preparedness efforts into lasting behaviour change, highlighting difficulties in translating preparedness strategies into actual practice (Amberson et al., 2024, p. 22-23). This suggests that access to relevant and timely information is important for motivating behaviour, but its effectiveness depends on individual and social factors (Tan et al., 2024, p. 9). This aligns with research showing that people may be aware of risks but still lack the motivation, confidence or ability to act, meaning that communication needs to combine awareness with clear and practical guidance (Eriksson, 2024, p. 17-18).

This behavioural perspective is supported by Amberson et al. (2024), who emphasise the need for efforts that address social support, education and behavioural change in order to improve preparedness (Amberson et al., 2024, p. 3-4). While information remains important, these studies suggest that preparedness should be understood as a process shaped by capability, opportunity and motivation rather than as a direct outcome of information provision. At the same time, Kohn et al. (2012) highlight limitations in the research field, including a lack of consistent definitions and standardised ways of measuring preparedness, as well as limited evidence linking preparedness measures such as emergency kits or plans, to actual outcomes in disasters (Kohn et al., 2012, p. 229-230). This suggests that preparedness is not just about awareness or having resources, but also about how people interpret and act on preparedness information in practice. For this thesis, these insights are important because they suggest that residents' preparedness cannot be understood only in terms of access to information. It must also be analysed in relation to how preparedness communication is interpreted in everyday life, what practical barriers residents face and whether they perceive themselves as capable of acting on the guidance provided.

2.4 Linking institutional and individual preparedness

Preparedness can be understood as a multi-level process shaped by interactions between institutional conditions and individual factors. Preparedness can also be understood as a collective capacity shaped by social networks, communication and shared resources, as well as the ability to act together under uncertain situations (Norris et al., 2007, p. 136-137). Research also emphasises that community resilience is not only dependent on physical infrastructure, but is shaped by social capital, including trust, networks and social relationships, which help people coordinate and support each other during crises (Aldrich & Meyer, 2015, p. 254-255). This perspective challenges traditional policy approaches that prioritise technical solutions, suggesting instead that investments in social infrastructure and community networks are equally important for strengthening preparedness and resilience (Aldrich & Meyer, 2015, p. 255). Research highlights how infrastructure systems are interconnected and dependent on each other (Kaneberg, 2018, p. 22-23). Disruptions in one system, such as electricity or communication, can quickly spread across sectors and affect overall preparedness. At the same time, divided responsibilities and coordination challenges make preparedness more difficult to manage (Heidenfors Armblad, 2023, p. 38-39). In addition, individual-level factors such as behaviour and access to resources influence preparedness outcomes. Preparedness depends on the interaction between structural conditions and individual capacities rather than on separate factors (Levac et al., 2012, p. 726-727).

Although these perspectives complement each other, they are often studied separately and at different levels. As a result, existing research provides limited insight into how institutional and structural conditions interact with individual-level preparedness in practice. Preparedness develops through the interaction between risk assessment, communication, institutions and public participation, rather than through isolated efforts (Renn, 2008, p. 9). This is further supported by research showing that the complex connections between systems and actors require integrated approaches that consider both institutional and behavioural aspects of preparedness (Kaneberg, 2018, p. 24). While Kaneberg (2018) and Heidenfors Armblad (2023) explain why preparedness systems are

difficult to coordinate, Levac et al. (2012), Ning et al. (2021) and Amberson et al. (2021) explain why individuals may not act on preparedness information even when it is available. This is further supported by research showing that preparedness efforts often have limited effects on behaviour (Amberson et al., 2021, p. 3-4). Preparedness cannot be explained through systemic or individual perspectives alone, but requires an integrated approach linking governance structures to everyday understandings of risk and responsibility. From this perspective, preparedness can be understood as a process shaped by how individuals interpret institutional communication, evaluate risks and consider available actions in practice (Lindell & Perry, 2012, p. 617 & 624). Communication can be understood as an important link between institutional preparedness efforts and individual behaviour, but its effectiveness depends on how information is interpreted, trusted and used in decision-making (Steelman & McCaffrey, 2012, p. 684-685).

Research also shows that communication gaps may arise when the information provided by authorities does not align with citizens' needs, as individuals tend to focus on immediate, practical concerns while authorities often communicate more general preparedness and response information (Hong et al., 2018, p. 1033-1034). This can lead to situations where citizens rely on informal networks or communication with others instead of official sources, highlighting limitations in top-down communication approaches during crises (Hong et al., 2018, p. 1033). Many citizens do not actively engage with official communication channels, partly because they are unsure which sources to trust or how to access relevant information (Hong et al., 2018, p. 1036). In addition, effective communication systems and access to reliable information are central components of community resilience, as they enable coordination, shared understanding and collective action during crises (Norris et al., 2007, p. 140). From this perspective, risk and preparedness are not only technical or individual issues, but are shaped by broader social systems, institutions and power structures that influence both vulnerability and the ability to respond (Tierney, 2014, p. 5 & 230). Research also emphasises that crises are rarely handled by a single actor alone, they involve multiple organisations, professions and the public, which means that preparedness and crisis response require collective action and are difficult to coordinate (Boin et al., 2005, p. 558).

A central tension in the literature lies between institutional expectations and lived preparedness. This tension can be understood as a challenge of making sense of complex and uncertain situations. Institutions must translate these into clear narratives that enable coordinated action across different actors and levels (Boin et al., 2005, p. 558). No single communication strategy is sufficient for creating a culture of preparedness. Instead, effective preparedness communication requires a combination of information, motivation, dialogue and community engagement, adapted to local social conditions and citizens' everyday realities (Eriksson, 2024, p. 22-23). Preparedness is often framed by institutions as a matter of responsibility, planning and information provision, while research shows that preparedness behaviour is shaped by perception, trust, resources and everyday practices. This suggests that societies do not respond to all risks equally, but prioritise some risks over others based on social values, institutional arrangements and shared worldviews, rather than objective danger alone (Douglas & Wildavsky, 1983, p. 7-8). A mismatch therefore emerges between how preparedness is communicated and how it is understood and translated into practice.

From this perspective, disagreement about which risks matter most is not necessarily a sign of misinformation or irrational thinking, but a natural outcome of risk judgments being shaped by different social values and ways of organising society (Douglas & Wildavsky, 1983, p. 4-5). Understanding this mismatch is therefore central to explaining why preparedness policies and communication strategies do not always translate into practical preparedness at the local level. Furthermore, modern societies tend to underestimate low-probability but high-consequence events as planning is often based on past experiences

rather than potential future events, which limits preparedness for unexpected crises (Tierney, 2014, p. 73-74). This relationship between institutional structures and individual preparedness can also be understood through the concept of urban transformative capacity. Rather than viewing preparedness as a result of planning or individual behaviour alone, this perspective emphasises the importance of interaction, participation and collective learning processes across levels (Wolfram, 2016, p. 126 & 129). It suggests that preparedness depends not only on communication and individual motivation, but also on how governance structures enable collaboration and active engagement among different actors. Preparedness is therefore best understood as a collective process rather than solely an institutional or individual outcome.

2.5 Research gap

Research on preparedness has developed across different areas and studies often focus on either individual behaviour or broader institutional systems rather than clearly linking the two (Tierney, 2014, p. 8 & 24). System-level studies explain how preparedness is shaped by infrastructure, governance and collaboration challenges, while local and individual-level studies explain why individuals do or do not prepare. However, few studies integrate these perspectives within the same empirical context, which limits the ability of existing research to explain how preparedness intentions are connected to practical action (Kaneberg, 2018, p. 5-6). Similar limitations are also reflected in household preparedness research (Levac et al., 2012, p. 728). This reflects a broader limitation in crisis research, where studies often focus either on risk perception or technical risk analysis, while paying less attention to how risks are shaped by social and institutional processes (Tierney, 2014, p. 8 & 50). It is also linked to a broader institutional challenge in crisis management research, that preparedness must be maintained over time even though crises are relatively rare and many leaders and organisations have limited direct experience of managing them (Boin et al., 2005, p. 559).
A further challenge is that increasing complexity and uncertainty make it difficult to translate formal risk management frameworks into effective and coordinated action in practice (Renn, 2008, p. 7 & 9).

Preparedness is often measured in terms of awareness or resources, rather than actual behavioural outcomes in crisis situations (Kohn et al., 2012, p. 220 & 230). Moreover, the effectiveness of common preparedness efforts remains uncertain, as their impacts on knowledge and preparedness are limited and inconsistent. This highlights the need for more research in this area (Amberson et al., 2024, p. 22-23). This points to a broader challenge, as strengthening preparedness requires not only individual behaviour change but also the development of collective capacities and social structures that support coordinated action (Norris et al., 2007, p. 143). In particular, previous research highlights limitations in how preparedness planning is coordinated across actors and levels, while paying less attention to how such planning is understood and acted upon by individuals (Kaneberg, 2018, p. 138). Research further shows that preparedness is shaped by how individuals interpret and respond to risk information (Ning et al., 2021, p. 2-3). These communication challenges become particularly important at the municipal level as research shows that national preparedness messages must be adapted to local risks, social conditions and citizens' everyday contexts in order to be meaningful and practical (Eriksson, 2024, p. 22). This thesis addresses this research gap by examining how municipal preparedness planning and communication relate to residents' perceived preparedness and intended actions within a municipal context. Previous research shows that preparedness behaviour is shaped by how individuals interpret risk and responsibility in everyday life (Levac et al., 2012, p. 730). The study therefore contributes to a more integrated understanding of preparedness in urban contexts.

3. Theoretical Framework

This chapter presents the theoretical framework that guides the analysis of municipal preparedness communication and residents' perceived preparedness. The study combines crisis and risk communication theory with risk perception theory in order to examine both how preparedness is institutionally framed and how it is understood at the individual level. While crisis communication theory provides an institutional perspective on planning and communication processes, risk perception theory offers an individual-level lens for understanding how residents interpret and respond to communicated risks. In addition, perspectives from urban transformative capacity are used to examine how preparedness is organised and governed at the municipal level. Together, these perspectives enable analysis of how institutional intentions relate to residents' preparedness.

3.1 Theoretical Perspectives

3.1.1 Crisis and Risk Communication

The theoretical framework of crisis and risk communication provides an analytical framework for understanding how information about potential crises is produced, communicated and interpreted before, during and after a crisis (Coombs, 2019, p. 10 & 19). Rather than viewing crises solely as objective events, crisis communication theory emphasises the role of stakeholder perceptions, expectations and communication in shaping how crises are understood and managed (Coombs, 2019, p. 2-3). According to Coombs (2019), a crisis can be understood as a disruption that creates shared stress and threatens what stakeholders normally expect to function smoothly (Coombs, 2019, p. 2 & 4). Crises are therefore not defined only by events themselves but by how they are perceived and interpreted by those affected. This understanding is particularly relevant in the context of public preparedness where residents' perceptions of risk and responsibility influence whether preparedness information is taken seriously and translated into action. While this framework is primarily developed in relation to organisations, its focus on perception, preparedness and communication is highly relevant to crisis management and municipal preparedness planning. In this study, crisis is understood as a broad concept referring to severe disruptions that challenge the functioning of social systems, including events such as power outages, cyber incidents, extreme weather events and war (Coombs, 2019, p. 2-4). While crises can be institutionally defined as disruptive events requiring coordinated response, whether an event is recognised and experienced as a crisis also depends on how it is perceived by affected individuals (Slovic, 2000, p. 392-393).

A central aspect of Coombs's (2019) framework is the phase-based model of crisis management, which highlights three main phases: the pre-crisis phase, the crisis response phase and the post-crisis phase (Coombs, 2019, p. 10-11). The pre-crisis phase focuses on activities that take place before a crisis occurs such as signal detection, prevention and crisis preparation. The crisis response phase concerns the management and communication that take place during an ongoing crisis, while the post-crisis phase focuses on learning, recovery and evaluation after the crisis has passed (Coombs, 2019, p. 10-11). In this study, particular attention is given to the pre-crisis phase, as it is especially relevant for understanding preparedness communication. In this phase, communication is used not to respond to an ongoing crisis but to raise awareness, clarify responsibilities and enable preventative action before a disruption occurs (Coombs, 2019, p. 19-20). Municipal preparedness communication including guidelines, plans and public information can therefore be understood as a form of pre-crisis communication aimed at reducing uncertainty and strengthening societal preparedness.

Within this framework, crisis preparedness refers to actions taken before a crisis in order to reduce potential impacts and strengthen the capacity to respond. Preparedness includes identifying vulnerabilities, developing plans and communicating expectations and responsibilities before a crisis occurs (Coombs, 2019, p. 10-11). It therefore involves not only

technical planning, but also communication processes that shape how stakeholders understand risks and their role in responding to crises. Crisis and risk communication theory also highlights the unpredictability of crises. While crises cannot always be prevented, they can often be anticipated and preparation is therefore a central component of effective crisis management (Coombs, 2019, p. 4). From this perspective, preparedness communication is not only about providing information but about supporting an understanding that enables residents to act. Crisis and risk communication in this study therefore refers to the processes through which information about potential or ongoing crises is communicated in order to shape awareness, preparedness and expected action (Coombs, 2019, p. 10-11 & 19-20). Communication before a crisis plays a key role in shaping stakeholder expectations, perceptions of responsibility and preparedness to act (Coombs, 2019, p. 10-11).

In summary, crisis and risk communication theory is used to understand how preparedness information is communicated by public authorities and how responsibilities and expected actions are defined. The theory highlights the importance of perception, responsibility and action in shaping preparedness outcomes. By focusing on the pre-crisis phase and preparedness communication, this study examines how municipal preparedness communication is designed to influence residents' preparedness and intended actions in potential crisis situations.

3.1.2 The Perception of Risk

Risk perception theory provides a perspective on how individuals understand and respond to information about potential crises. Rather than viewing risk as an objective and measurable phenomenon, risk perception theory emphasises that risk is shaped by human interpretation, experience and social context (Slovic, 2000, p. 392-393). Slovic (2000) argues that people do not base their perceptions of risk solely on statistical probability or expert calculations. Instead, risk perceptions are influenced by qualitative factors such as emotions, perceived control, familiarity and trust in institutions (Slovic, 2000, p. 233 & 392). Risks that are perceived as unfamiliar, uncontrollable or potentially catastrophic tend to generate higher levels of concern, while risks that are familiar or perceived as manageable are often underestimated or ignored. This means that the same crisis can be perceived very differently by experts and by the public (Slovic, 2000, p. 394-395).

Slovic (2000) argues that risks are not perceived solely on the basis of their characteristics. Instead, public reactions to risk are shaped through communication and social interaction. Slovic (2000) introduces the concept of the "social amplification of risk", explaining that risk perceptions are shaped through communication processes involving media, institutions and cultural narratives. This can either increase or reduce public concern beyond what technical analyses would predict (Slovic, 2000, p. 234-235). This perspective is particularly relevant for municipal preparedness communication, as it suggests that the way information is framed and communicated may intensify or weaken residents' perceived urgency and willingness to prepare. From this perspective, preparedness at the individual level is influenced not only by access to information, but by how serious risks are perceived to be, how controllable they appear and how personally relevant they feel (Slovic, 2000, p. 233-234). Even when institutional guidance is clear, individuals may be less likely to prepare if risks are perceived as unlikely, distant or primarily managed by public authorities. Preparedness at the local and individual level therefore depends not only on institutional planning and communication, but also on how residents interpret risks, perceive responsibility and evaluate their own ability to act. This is particularly important in urban contexts where dependence on infrastructure and public services may increase vulnerability during disruptions, while insufficient preparedness among residents may place additional pressure on institutional response systems (Lavelle, 2012, p. 1-2).

A key assumption in Slovic's (2000) work is that risk cannot be understood independently of human perception. He challenges the idea of risk as an objective and

measurable reality and instead frames it as an analytical tool developed by humans to make sense of uncertainty. As Slovic (2000) states:

"In this view, risk does not exist 'out there', independent of our minds and cultures, waiting to be measured. Instead, human beings have invented the concept risk to help them understand and cope with the dangers and uncertainties of life. Although these dangers are real, there is no such thing as 'real risk' or 'objective risk'." - (Slovic, 2000, p. 392)

Slovic demonstrates that public perceptions of risk are multidimensional and include considerations such as voluntariness, equity and controllability (Slovic, 2000, p. 394-395). If a risk is perceived as involuntary rather than voluntary or as primarily managed by authorities rather than individuals, people may be less likely to take personal responsibility for preparedness. This understanding is important and relevant for preparedness communication. If individuals understand risk through their own perceptions, experiences and judgments, providing accurate information alone is insufficient to ensure that they recognise risks or translate preparedness information into action. According to Slovic (2000), public responses to risk information are shaped by judgments, previous experiences and levels of trust in authorities, rather than by technical risk assessments (Slovic, 2000, p. 392-393). In the context of crisis and war preparedness, this perspective helps explain why residents may feel insufficiently motivated to prepare despite being exposed to preparedness information. This also suggests that individuals' preparedness behaviour is influenced not only by the availability of information, but by how risks are perceived, interpreted and judged in relation to personal relevance and responsibility. Hazards such as large-scale power outages, cyber incidents or war may be perceived as distant, unlikely or primarily the responsibility of public authorities. High levels of trust in institutions and dependence on critical infrastructure can further reduce individuals' perceived personal responsibility and sense of urgency (Slovic, 2000, p. 390 & 396).

In this study, the perception of risk is used as an analytical lens to examine how municipal preparedness communication is interpreted by residents and how this interpretation relates to perceived preparedness and intended actions in crisis scenarios. By focusing on subjective risk perception rather than objective risk, the theory provides a framework for analysing gaps between institutional preparedness planning and residents' capacity to act. This perspective is particularly relevant for understanding why communicated preparedness measures do not always translate into individual preparedness, even in contexts where potential threats are real and well-documented.

3.1.3 Urban Transformative Capacity and Governance

To complement the perspectives on crisis and risk communication and risk perception theory, this study integrates insights from urban transformative capacity as an analytical lens for understanding how preparedness is organised at the municipal level. According to Wolfram (2016), urban transformative capacity refers to the collective ability of urban actors to initiate and implement systemic change, emphasising inclusive governance, cross-level collaboration and social learning processes (Wolfram, 2016, p. 126). This perspective is used to examine the extent to which preparedness is organised through more centralised governance structures or through inclusive and participatory processes that actively involve residents (Wolfram, 2016, p. 126-127). In this study, urban transformative capacity functions as a bridging concept between institutional and individual levels, enabling analysis of how governance structures, communication practices and resident engagement interact in shaping preparedness outcomes. This allows the study to analyse preparedness not only as a matter of information and perception, but as a question of governance capacity and participation.

3.2 Analytical framework

This study applies an analytical framework that combines crisis and risk communication theory, risk perception theory and urban transformative capacity. The framework is used to examine how municipal preparedness planning and communication are translated into residents' perceived preparedness and intended actions. By combining an institutional perspective with an individual-level perspective, the framework enables analysis of both how preparedness is communicated and how it is interpreted and acted upon.

From an institutional perspective, crisis and risk communication theory is used to analyse how Norrköping municipality frames preparedness, including which risks are prioritised, how responsibilities are communicated and what actions residents are expected to take. The focus on the pre-crisis phase is particularly relevant, as preparedness communication aims to raise awareness, clarify responsibilities and enable preventative action before a disruption occurs (Coombs, 2019, p. 10-11). Urban transformative capacity is used to examine how preparedness is organised at the municipal level, including whether preparedness is shaped through hierarchical information provision or more inclusive and participatory governance processes (Wolfram, 2016, p. 126-127). At the individual level, risk perception theory is used to analyse how residents interpret preparedness communication and perceive potential risks. This includes analytical aspects such as trust, perceived controllability, personal relevance and perceived responsibility (Slovic, 2000, p. 233-234). Risks are also understood as socially and psychologically constructed rather than purely objective phenomena (Slovic, 2000, p. 392-393). Together, these perspectives make it possible to identify how institutional expectations differ from residents' interpretations, perceived preparedness and intended actions in crisis scenarios.

4. Method

This chapter presents the methodological approach used in the study. It outlines the overall research design, the data collection methods and the analytical strategy applied to examine the relationship between institutional preparedness communication and residents' perceived preparedness and intended actions. The chapter also discusses sampling strategies, ethical considerations and methodological limitations.

4.1 Research Design

The study adopted a pragmatic epistemological approach. Pragmatism emphasises selecting research methods that best address the research problem rather than following a single methodological approach (Creswell, 2009, p. 32 & 188). Research design involves not only technical decisions but also assumptions about how knowledge is produced and how theory relates to empirical research (Creswell, 2009, p. 32). A mixed-methods approach was suitable for this study, as it allowed for the analysis of both measurable patterns and interpretative processes (Creswell, 2009, p. 188). Based on this epistemological position, the study adopted a mixed-methods case study design. It was used to examine how crisis and war preparedness was planned and communicated at the municipal level and how such communication aligned with residents' perceived preparedness and intended actions. From this perspective, quantitative and qualitative approaches were combined to examine different aspects of the same research problem. The choice of a mixed-methods design was therefore not simply about using multiple methods, but about the practical need to examine both measurable patterns and residents' interpretations of preparedness communication. Alternative approaches could have been considered. A purely quantitative design could have provided more generalisable results, while a purely qualitative approach could have enabled deeper insights into everyday practices. However, these approaches would not have captured both the breadth and depth required to address the research aim.

More specifically, the study used a sequential explanatory design. Document analysis was conducted first to examine institutional preparedness and to inform the development of the survey. Survey data were then collected and used to identify patterns, which then informed the interview phase. Sequential explanatory designs are particularly suitable when the researcher first seeks to identify patterns and then explain them through qualitative data (Creswell, 2009, p. 194). The study was based on three empirical methods: document analysis, a survey and semi-structured interviews. Document analysis was conducted first in order to examine how preparedness was planned and communicated and to inform the development of survey items and crisis scenarios. The quantitative and qualitative survey was then used to identify patterns in perceived preparedness, trust, perceived responsibility and intended actions among residents (Creswell, 2009, p. 191). The interviews were then used to contextualise and interpret patterns identified in the survey findings. In this design, the different phases were linked, with each stage of data collection building on the results from the previous one (Fetters et al., 2013, p. 2140). Creswell (2009) argues that this strategy is particularly suitable when quantitative findings require further exploration, which aligns with the study's aim of examining why potential gaps between institutional intentions and resident perceptions emerge (Creswell, 2009, p. 191). The combination of document analysis, survey data and semi-structured interviews enabled triangulation of institutional and resident perspectives, strengthening analytical depth (Creswell, 2009, p. 30-31).

Fetters et al. (2013, p. 2140) explain that mixed-methods research requires integration at different stages of the research process, including research design, data collection and interpretation. In this study, findings from the document analysis informed the construction of survey questions and crisis scenarios, while preliminary survey patterns guided the development of interview questions. The different data sources were compared in the analysis to examine whether they confirmed, complemented or differed from one another (Fetters et al., 2013, p. 2144). Diverging findings were not treated as weaknesses, but as

meaningful indications of differences between institutional planning and residents' intended actions.

The case study design enabled in-depth analysis of preparedness governance within a defined municipal context (Creswell, 2009, p. 30). Preparedness planning in Sweden operates through interconnected governance structures across multiple levels (Kaneberg, 2018, p. 5-6). At the same time, some critical societal functions are operated by private actors, making effective public-private collaboration central to civil preparedness (Heidenfors Armblad, 2023, p. 6-7). By focusing on one municipality, the study was able to analyse how national preparedness expectations are translated into local communication and then interpreted by residents. The purpose was not to produce statistically generalisable findings about all municipalities, but to examine how theoretical concepts such as responsibility and perceived control are expressed within a specific context. This reflects a qualitative approach focused on interpreting themes and patterns in the data rather than statistical generalisation (Creswell, 2009, p. 32). In addition, the study focused on residents' perceived preparedness and intended actions rather than actual behaviour in real crisis situations.

4.2 Data Collection

4.2.1 Document Analysis

Document analysis was the first empirical phase and served both exploratory and analytical purposes. Document analysis is a systematic qualitative research method used to examine printed and electronic documents in order to identify meaning and develop understanding (Bowen, 2009, p. 27). In qualitative research, documents are understood as socially produced texts that reflect institutional priorities, governance structures and underlying assumptions rather than as neutral sources of information (Creswell, 2009, p. 169). In the context of crisis preparedness, planning documents and public communication materials are particularly relevant because they define how risks are framed and how responsibility is distributed before crises occur. The analysed material included municipal crisis management plans, preparedness strategies, communication policies and publicly available preparedness information directed at residents, as well as relevant national guidance documents. Selection was strategic and guided by analytical relevance, focusing on documents that explicitly address crisis and war preparedness and communication toward residents (Creswell, 2009, p. 166). The purpose of the document analysis was to identify how preparedness is framed institutionally, how residents are positioned within municipal preparedness planning and communication and which assumptions are embedded in communication strategies.

In the Swedish context, civil preparedness has received increased attention due to a more uncertain security environment and a renewed focus on total defence (Heidenfors Armblad, 2023, p. 6-7). Responsibilities for preparedness are distributed across national, regional and municipal levels, creating a multi-level governance structure that requires coordination and role clarification (Kaneberg, 2018, p. 5-6). Within this structure, municipalities play a central role in translating national preparedness requirements into local planning and public communication (Kaneberg, 2018, p. 24 & 30). Written plans and communication strategies therefore become key instruments for defining expectations and responsibilities toward residents. Municipal documents function not only as administrative texts but as instruments for structuring responsibility and behavioural guidance within a complex preparedness system (Kaneberg, 2018, p. 24 & 30). Within this structure, documents define institutional expectations by clarifying responsibilities, prioritising risks and outlining forms of cooperation (Heidenfors Armblad, 2023, p. 19 & 22). Analysing these documents therefore provides insight into how municipalities interpret national preparedness requirements and translate them into local communication and planning frameworks.

Crisis communication theory highlights that the pre-crisis phase involves clarifying

expectations and defining stakeholder roles (Coombs, 2019, p. 10-11). Municipal documents therefore represent empirical expressions of institutional expectations regarding resident behaviour. In particular, pre-crisis communication seeks to establish credibility and define what stakeholders are expected to know and do before a crisis occurs. Municipal preparedness communication and public information materials can be understood as proactive governance tools that define behavioural expectations toward residents in potential crisis or war scenarios. At the same time, risk perception theory emphasises that communicated risk is actively interpreted rather than neutrally received (Slovic, 2000, p. 392-393). Preparedness and crisis-related information is interpreted through individuals' perceptions of control, trust and prior experience, meaning that institutional framings may not translate directly into intended action (Slovic, 2000, p. 233-234). This theoretical perspective provides a framework for examining preparedness documents as one side of the relationship between institutional expectations and residents' perceived preparedness and behavioural intentions.

Document analysis established the formal institutional perspective in this thesis, as preparedness planning at strategic and implementation levels defines roles and expectations before crises occur (Kaneberg, 2018, p. 6 & 30). This approach made it possible to identify institutional assumptions beyond the formal wording of the documents and strengthened the analytical depth. More specifically, the document analysis included approximately 12 documents consisting of municipal crisis management plans, preparedness strategies, communication policies and publicly available preparedness information directed at residents as well as national guidance documents. Documents were included if they addressed crisis or war preparedness, pre-crisis communication or behavioural guidance directed toward residents. This strategic inclusion ensured alignment with the study's theoretical focus on responsibility attribution, perceived control and communication framing (Creswell, 2009, p. 166).

4.2.2 Survey

The survey was the primary empirical source in the study and examined how residents perceived preparedness communication and described intended actions in potential crisis situations. A total of 100 responses were collected of which 94 were complete and included in the analysis. The survey measured residents' exposure to preparedness communication, perceived clarity of information, trust in authorities, perceived likelihood of crisis, perceived responsibility and intended actions in scenario-based situations. Survey research is appropriate when the aim is to measure attitudes, perceptions and behavioural intentions within a defined population (Creswell, 2009, p. 138).

The development of the survey was informed by both the theoretical framework and the document analysis. The document analysis identified how municipalities communicate preparedness responsibilities and behavioural expectations toward residents. These findings were used to formulate survey questions and scenarios that reflected the type of information residents are expected to receive and act upon. In addition, theoretical concepts from crisis communication theory and risk perception theory guided the development of survey questions and measures. Construct validity refers to the need for a clear link between theoretical concepts and the survey questions used to measure them (Creswell, 2009, p. 141-142). In this study, questions measuring trust reflected crisis communication theory's focus on credibility and public trust in authorities. These questions examined residents' trust in municipal preparedness communication and in the authorities responsible for providing crisis information (Coombs, 2019, p. 19-20). Questions concerning perceived likelihood of crisis and perceived control were based on risk perception theory, which highlights that risk judgments are shaped by individual perceptions and interpretations rather than objective statistical likelihood (Slovic, 2000, p. 233-234). Questions addressing responsibility examined whether residents perceived preparedness as primarily an individual or institutional responsibility.

The survey included closed-ended questions measuring exposure to preparedness communication, perceived responsibility, trust and perceived preparedness. Another central component consisted of open-ended scenario-based questions designed to capture intended actions under different conditions. The survey therefore combined structured Likert-scale questions with open-ended responses. Likert-scale questions present respondents with a set of ordered response options. In this study, a 10-point scale ranging from strongly disagree to strongly agree was used. These questions allow respondents to indicate levels of agreement or certainty and enable comparison across participants. Structured questions improve reliability by reducing uncertainty in interpretation and coding (Bryman, 2012, p. 212). Using standardised survey questions also contributes to measurement reliability by ensuring that all respondents interpret the questions in a comparable way (Bryman, 2012, p. 212-213). However, relying solely on structured questions risks capturing only general awareness rather than actual preparedness reasoning. Research on preparedness behaviour shows that awareness does not necessarily translate into preparedness actions (Lavelle, 2012, p. 25-26). The inclusion of open-ended questions and scenario-based questions therefore allow respondents to describe how they would act in specific crisis situations, connecting abstract perceptions with intended actions. Scenario-based questions are particularly useful for examining how individuals interpret risks, evaluate protective actions and describe intended behaviour in hypothetical crisis situations. This reflects central elements of the Protective Action Decision Model, which emphasises that preparedness behaviour is shaped by how individuals interpret threats, responsibilities and possible actions under conditions of uncertainty (Lindell & Perry, 2012, p. 617 & 621).

The target population of the survey consisted of residents aged 18 years and older living in Norrköping municipality. Participation was restricted to this group because the study examined how adult residents interpreted municipal preparedness communication and their potential role in crisis situations. A filter question at the beginning of the survey ensured that respondents who did not live in Norrköping could not proceed with the questionnaire. The survey was distributed digitally using Google Forms and could be accessed through either a direct link or a QR code. The survey used a non-probability sampling strategy, meaning that respondents are not selected through random sampling methods (Bryman, 2012, p. 11). While probability sampling would allow stronger statistical generalisation, it was not feasible within the scope of this thesis. In practice, sampling strategies in social research are often influenced by available resources and access to respondents (Bryman, 2012, p. 11). The aim of the survey was therefore analytical rather than statistical generalisation. The results were analysed in relation to theoretical concepts such as perceived control, trust and perceived responsibility, following a qualitative approach focused on identifying themes and patterns in the data rather than statistical generalisation (Creswell, 2009, p. 32). A potential limitation of the sampling strategy is that participation may vary across age groups, meaning that responses may not be evenly distributed across the adult population.

The survey was conducted in Swedish to ensure that the questions were clear and understandable to respondents and to minimise potential misunderstandings between the researcher and participants. Preparedness communication often involves specific terms and expressions and collecting responses in participants' first language supports both clarity and validity. The survey did not collect names, contact details or other directly identifying information in order to maintain respondent anonymity. For the purposes of this thesis, the survey questions and responses were translated into English. Because translation involves choices in wording, care was taken to preserve the meaning of respondents' answers as closely as possible (Creswell, 2009, p. 165). It should be noted that survey responses may be influenced by bias, as respondents may overestimate their level of preparedness or provide socially desirable answers.

4.2.3 Semi-structured Interviews

Semi-structured interviews were conducted to deepen the understanding of how crisis management, preparedness planning and communication are organised and justified at the municipal level. Two in-person interviews were conducted with municipal officials working with crisis preparedness and communication functions in Norrköping municipality. Interviews are particularly appropriate when the aim is to explore meaning, reasoning and institutional interpretation rather than to measure quantitative patterns (Bryman, 2012, p. 470). Semi-structured interviews enable in-depth exploration through prepared questions while remaining flexible enough to follow up on topics that emerge during the conversation (Kvale & Brinkmann, 2015, p. 31-32). In this study, interviews allowed examination of how municipal officials themselves understood responsibility distribution, communication challenges and residents' preparedness. Interview participants were selected strategically from municipal functions responsible for crisis preparedness and public communication. Participants were selected through purposeful sampling because of their direct involvement in preparedness planning, crisis management or communication activities within the municipality. This approach is consistent with Creswell's (2009, p. 166) recommendation that qualitative researchers select participants who can best provide insight into the research problem.

More specifically, the interviews involved two municipal officials working with crisis preparedness and communication in Norrköping municipality. One participant worked within the municipal communication department and was responsible for coordinating the municipality's crisis communication function (Kommunikatör i beredskap, KiB). The second participant worked within the municipality's safety and security department as a strategic coordinator responsible for the duty officer function (Tjänsteman i beredskap, TiB). These roles were central in the municipality's crisis preparedness structure, as they involved coordinating communication and operational response during incidents or crises. Including participants from both functions allowed the study to capture perspectives from both preparedness coordination and crisis communication within the municipal organisation. Because these roles were directly involved in preparedness coordination and crisis communication, the participants provided insights into how municipal preparedness planning and communication strategies were implemented in practice.

The interview guide was informed by preliminary findings from the document analysis and the survey. Patterns and responses identified in the survey results were used to formulate interview questions that explored how municipal officials interpreted residents' reported preparedness and perceived responsibilities. In addition to capturing officials' perspectives on preparedness communication, the interviews also examined how these survey findings corresponded to current municipal practices. They also explored whether there were ongoing or planned initiatives aimed at addressing potential gaps identified in residents' responses. The choice of semi-structured interviews reflected the need to balance structure and flexibility. Bryman (2012, p. 471) explains that semi-structured interviews are suitable when the researcher has defined areas but seeks depth and elaboration. This was consistent with the sequential explanatory design of the study. Survey findings therefore guided the development of interview questions, enabling further exploration between institutional intentions and residents' reported preparedness. Fetters et al. (2013, p. 2140 & 2145) describe this as integration through connecting, where one phase of data collection guides the next stage of data collection.

Individual interviews were chosen over group interviews and focus groups. Bryman (2012, p. 517) notes that focus groups involve group dynamics that may limit different views and complicate interpretation. Given that crisis management may involve institutional sensitivities and hierarchical structures, individual interviews were considered more appropriate for encouraging open reflections. The interviews were analysed using the same thematic analytical framework as the document material and survey. Applying a consistent

analytical method across datasets strengthens consistency and supports integration (Braun & Clarke, 2006, p. 15-16). In line with crisis communication theory, particular attention was paid to how officials described the pre-crisis phase and the responsibilities of the municipality, how they framed the responsibilities of both residents and the municipality and how they perceived behavioural barriers to preparedness (Coombs, 2019, p. 10-11). The interviews therefore functioned as a bridge between formal institutional framing and lived governance practice.

4.3 Sampling and Selection

The study used three forms of empirical material: documents, survey responses from residents and semi-structured interviews with municipal officials. Each dataset was selected strategically in relation to the study's research questions and mixed-methods design (Bryman, 2012, p. 11-12). The document material consisted of municipal and national preparedness documents addressing crisis preparedness, communication and responsibility distribution toward residents. These documents were selected based on their analytical relevance to the study's focus on pre-crisis communication and preparedness governance (Creswell, 2009, p. 165-166). The survey targeted adult residents living in Norrköping municipality and used a non-probability sampling strategy. The aim was not statistical representativeness, but to identify patterns in perceived preparedness, responsibility and intended actions in relation to the theoretical framework (Creswell, 2009, p. 138 & 142). Interview participants were selected through purposeful sampling from municipal crisis preparedness and communication functions in Norrköping municipality. Participants were chosen based on their professional involvement in preparedness planning and communication activities (Creswell, 2009, p. 166). Both the survey and interviews were conducted in Swedish and later translated into English for the analysis and presentation of results. Care was taken to preserve the meaning of participants' responses during translation (Creswell, 2009, p. 165).

4.4 Method of Analysis

All gathered data including documents, survey responses and interviews, were analysed using thematic analysis in order to ensure methodological consistency and enable comparison between institutional and resident perspectives. Braun and Clarke (2006, p. 6) describe thematic analysis as a flexible method for identifying patterns of meaning within qualitative datasets. Braun and Clarke (2006, p. 7) emphasise that themes do not passively "emerge" from data but are actively constructed through analytic engagement. In this study, thematic analysis was theoretically informed, meaning that coding was guided by concepts based on crisis communication and risk perception theory while remaining open to new insights from the data (Braun & Clarke, 2006, p. 12).

In this study, thematic analysis was used not only to describe patterns in the data but also to interpret them in relation to the theoretical framework. This approach acknowledges the researcher's active role in identifying patterns and selecting analytically relevant data (Braun & Clarke, 2006, p. 7). Coding decisions were therefore continuously evaluated in relation to both the empirical material and the theoretical framework, particularly when separating between semantic statements and latent governance assumptions (Braun & Clarke, 2006, p. 13). At the semantic level, explicit statements regarding responsibility and preparedness were examined. At the latent level, the analysis focused on underlying governance assumptions embedded in institutional and resident narratives such as implicit expectations of individual responsibility (Braun & Clarke, 2006, p. 12-13). In this thesis, coding decisions were informed by both the empirical material and the theoretical framework. The coding strategy combined deductive and inductive elements, meaning that the analysis was guided by theoretical concepts while remaining open to patterns emerging from the data (Braun & Clarke, 2006, p. 12).

The analysis proceeded through familiarisation, systematic coding, theme

development, review and refinement (Braun & Clarke, 2006, p. 16 & 20). Applying thematic analysis across qualitative datasets strengthens methodological coherence and supports the integration of findings. Quantitative survey data were analysed using descriptive statistics to identify patterns in respondents' answers. The aim was not hypothesis testing but identification of patterns in perceived preparedness and intended action (Creswell, 2009, p. 138). Integration occurred at the interpretation stage, where quantitative patterns were compared with qualitative themes to identify confirmation, complementary insights or differences (Fetters et al., 2013, p. 2144).

In line with Fetters et al. (2013, p. 2143-2144), particular attention was paid to the degree of "fit" between datasets, meaning how quantitative and qualitative findings support, complement or differ from each other. Confirmation strengthens the credibility of the findings, while complementary insights from different datasets can deepen the overall understanding of the residents' preparedness. Differences between datasets were not treated as methodological problems but as analytically meaningful patterns that may reveal variations in institutional framing, residents' interpretations or local conditions affecting preparedness (Fetters et al., 2013, p. 2144). This approach enhances the credibility of the mixed-methods design by making the integration process transparent and theoretically grounded. To enhance reliability, the same analytical approach was used across all data sources. However, qualitative data involves some subjectivity in interpretation. The combination of document analysis, survey data and interviews enables triangulation, which strengthens the credibility of the findings by providing multiple perspectives.

4.5 Ethical Considerations

Ethical considerations are essential to research legitimacy and methodological quality (Bryman, 2012, p. 130-131). The study followed established ethical principles of voluntary participation, informed consent and confidentiality. Informed consent is central in social research, as participants must be informed about the purpose of the study, the use of their data and their right to withdraw (Bryman, 2012, p. 138-139). In the survey, participants received written information about the study, anonymity and data protection before answering any questions. The information stated that participation is voluntary, that respondents may withdraw at any time and that no identifying personal data are collected. Participants were also informed that continuing the survey indicated their consent to participate in the study, in line with principles of informed consent (Bryman, 2012, p. 138-139).

Interview participants signed written consent agreements explaining study purpose, use of data and confidentiality procedures. The study also considered the potential for psychological discomfort. Questions concerning crisis and war scenarios may cause concern or anxiety among participants. In line with the ethical principle of avoiding harm, both survey and interview questions were therefore carefully formulated to minimise potential discomfort for participants (Bryman, 2012, p. 135). The scenarios were presented as hypothetical and analytical situations rather than alarmist descriptions and no graphic or disturbing details were included. Similarly, interview questions were designed to focus on perceptions, experiences and institutional practices rather than personal vulnerability. Confidentiality and data protection are treated as central ethical considerations. Bryman (2012, p. 137) emphasises the importance of protecting participant identity and ensuring secure handling of data. The survey included basic demographic questions regarding age, gender and place of residence within the municipality in order to allow for analytical comparisons between respondents, while avoiding the collection of identifying personal data. Interview data were anonymised during transcription in order to protect participants' identities. Identifying information was removed from the transcripts and replaced with anonymised names where necessary. While the researcher was aware of the participants' identities during the research process, this information was not included in the thesis.

In the survey, no direct personal identifiers such as names, addresses or contact details were collected. While this protects participants' privacy, it also means that the researcher cannot verify who is responding to the survey. Online surveys may therefore involve a risk that individuals outside the intended population participate or that responses cannot be linked to demographic balance across the population (Bryman, 2012, p. 140-141). This limitation was acknowledged and addressed through filter questions at the beginning of the survey to ensure that respondents were residents of Norrköping municipality and 18 years old or older. The survey design therefore attempted to balance accessibility with ethical limitations of personal data collection. The selection of interview participants also raises ethical considerations regarding representation and institutional perspectives. Interview participants were selected strategically from municipal functions responsible for crisis preparedness and communication. This strategy ensures that participants have relevant expertise, but it also means that the institutional perspective may reflect the perspectives of specific roles rather than the entire organisational structure. Recognising this limitation is part of responsible research practice and contributes to transparency regarding the interpretation of the findings (Creswell, 2009, p. 165-166).

Ethical reflection also applies to the document analysis. The analysed materials consist of publicly accessible policy documents and communication materials, and their interpretation is influenced by the researcher's prior knowledge, theoretical framework and analytical perspective (Braun & Clarke, 2006, p. 15). Qualitative analysis therefore requires awareness of how the researcher's assumptions may influence the identification of themes and interpretations (Braun & Clarke, 2006, p. 14-15). A reflexive approach involves continuously reflecting on how theoretical expectations, professional background or prior understanding of preparedness governance may influence analytical judgement (Creswell, 2009, p. 165 & 181). Ethical research practice is also closely related to the theoretical framework of the study. Since trust is a central concept in crisis communication research, credibility and transparency are important for maintaining confidence in institutional communication (Coombs, 2019, p. 19). Similarly, risk perception research emphasises that trust in authorities influences how individuals interpret and respond to risk information (Slovic, 2000, p. 396). Research that does not handle participant data responsibly may undermine the trust it seeks to study.

Linköping University is the personal data controller for the processing of personal data within the university's research and educational activities, including the collection of research data (LiU, n.d.). In accordance with Swedish data protection regulations and the General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR), the study minimised the collection of personal data and processed only information necessary for the analytical purpose. Participants were informed about how their data would be used, stored and eventually deleted. Personal data were handled safely and only stored for the time necessary to complete the research project. Additional guidance regarding the handling of personal data in student research is provided by Linköping University's data protection guidelines (LiU, n.d.). In addition, the study followed Swedish data protection guidance for research, which emphasises that the data controller is responsible for ensuring that personal data are processed in accordance with existing regulations (Integritetsskyddsmyndigheten, 2026). For this reason, the survey was designed to avoid login-based identifiers and the data were analysed in anonymised form.

4.6 Methodological Limitations

All research designs involve trade-offs and being transparent about methodological limitations strengthens the credibility of the study (Creswell, 2009, p. 180). The most significant limitation concerns sampling. The survey used a non-probability sampling strategy, which restricts statistical generalisation (Creswell, 2009, p. 140). The findings should therefore not be interpreted as representative of how the entire population of Norrköping perceives preparedness or would act in crisis situations. Instead, they were analysed in relation to theoretical concepts such as perceived control, trust and perceived

responsibility. Self-reported preparedness is another limitation, Lavelle (2012, p. 25-26) demonstrates that awareness does not necessarily translate into action. Similarly, intended actions described in scenario responses may differ from actual behaviour in real crisis situations. Scenario-based responses therefore capture intended rather than actual behaviour, although they still provide valuable insight into preparedness reasoning under constrained conditions.

The limited number of interviews restricted the range of institutional perspectives. However, qualitative research prioritises depth and contextual insight over representativeness (Creswell, 2009, p. 180). The single-case design also limited how far the findings could be applied beyond municipalities with similar governance structures. However, the purpose of the study was not statistical generalisation but to contribute to theoretical understanding (Creswell, 2009, p. 32). Finally, integration across methods requires careful interpretation, as Fetters et al. (2013, p. 2144) note that mixed-methods research may produce results that either support, complement or differ from each other. Differences should not be treated as methodological failure but as analytically meaningful evidence of challenges in translating planning into action. In this study, differences between institutional framing and residents' perceptions were interpreted as central empirical material rather than as methodological problems. Such differences may reveal gaps between institutional expectations and residents' understanding of preparedness responsibilities and intended actions. This means that the findings cannot fully capture how residents would act under real conditions, where constraints, uncertainty and stress may influence decision-making.

5. Results and Analysis

This chapter presents the empirical findings of the study and analyses them in relation to the theoretical framework. The aim is to examine how municipal crisis and war preparedness is planned and communicated and how this aligns with residents' perceived preparedness and intended actions. The chapter is structured around the study's mixed-method design and integrates findings from document analysis, survey data and semi-structured interviews. It begins by examining how preparedness is framed at the institutional level, followed by an analysis of residents' perceived preparedness and their intended actions in different crisis scenarios. A third section draws on semi-structured interviews with municipal actors to provide deeper insight into institutional perspectives on preparedness communication, including perceived challenges, constraints and interpretations of residents' preparedness. The final section brings together findings from document analysis, survey data and interviews in order to identify how communicated preparedness is understood and translated into practice. By combining these perspectives, the chapter provides a comprehensive analysis of preparedness as a multi-level process, where institutional communication and individual interpretation are examined in relation to preparedness outcomes.

5.1 Institutional Framing of Preparedness

The document analysis reveals that preparedness is framed as both a shared societal responsibility and an individual obligation. Across the analysed national and municipal preparedness documents, including MSB brochures, municipal preparedness material, communication guidelines and crisis management plans, crisis preparedness is presented as a collective effort requiring coordination between public authorities, private actors and residents.

The institutional framing of preparedness at the municipal level is closely aligned with national civil preparedness guidelines. The national brochure "*Om krisen eller kriget kommer*" from Myndigheten för samhällsskydd och beredskap (MSB) which has been distributed to all households in Sweden, explicitly states that individuals are expected to manage basic needs for at least one week without societal support (MSB, 2024, p. 6). Civil preparedness is framed not only as personal safety, but as a contribution to national resilience and total defence (MSB, 2024, p. 3 & 7). This national framing establishes expectations of individual responsibility that municipalities are required to communicate and implement at the local level. This shows that national and municipal levels are closely aligned, with local preparedness communication largely repeating national expectations of individual responsibility rather than adapting them to local contexts.

This alignment becomes particularly visible in Norrköpings municipal material, where the local brochure "*Var förberedd om krisen eller kriget kommer*" produced by Norrköping municipality similarly states that residents should be able to manage basic needs for several days, preferably up to one week, without external support (Norrköpings kommun, n.d.-b, p. 2). Preparedness is consistently framed across both national and municipal levels as an individual responsibility that contributes to the functioning of society as a whole.
While public authorities and municipalities are responsible for providing information, guidance and coordination, residents are expected to actively prepare themselves, stay informed and independently seek and apply preparedness information in everyday life. This places significant responsibility on individuals to translate institutional guidance into practical preparedness. The analysis therefore indicates a mismatch between institutional expectations and residents' interpretations of preparedness communication in practice. The brochure frames individual preparedness as a necessary condition for national resilience, particularly in situations where resources must be prioritised for the most vulnerable groups (MSB, 2024, p. 3). At the same time, the municipal brochure maintains the same underlying expectations, but makes them more concrete by specifying how different types of crises such

as power outages, flooding and water disruptions, may affect residents and what resources and supplies they are expected to have prepared (Norrköpings kommun, n.d.-b, p. 6 & 9).

This institutional framing reflects the pre-crisis phase described in crisis communication theory, where communication is used proactively to clarify expectations and responsibilities before a disruption occurs (Coombs, 2019, p. 10-11). However, it also indicates that preparedness communication is primarily used to define responsibilities rather than to engage with how residents interpret and act upon this information, highlighting a more top-down and information-driven communication approach. By defining preparedness as a civic duty, the documents frame preparedness as part of everyday responsibility and shape how residents are expected to act in crisis situations. However, previous research shows that such approaches do not necessarily lead to preparedness in practice (Levac et al., 2012, p. 730).

The distribution of the brochure to all households, as well as its availability in multiple languages and accessible formats, further illustrates the ambition to reach the entire population and normalise preparedness as a universal civic responsibility (MSB, 2026). By addressing both crisis and war scenarios and linking individual preparedness to Sweden's total defence system, the material reframes residents from being protected by the state to becoming responsible actors in maintaining national resilience. This shift is also visible in the municipal material, where residents are not only told to stay informed, but are expected to plan, prepare and act in ways that support the municipality's ability to prioritise limited resources during crises (Norrköpings kommun, n.d.-b, p. 2). This responsibility framing is also reflected in the municipality's general description of civil preparedness, where preparedness is presented as an integrated part of maintaining societal functions during crises (Norrköpings kommun, n.d.-a).

Similarly, Norrköping municipality states that crisis preparedness is a shared responsibility between the municipality and residents (Norrköpings kommun, 2026d). Residents are encouraged to prepare crisis kits, develop household crisis plans and familiarise themselves with warning systems (Norrköpings kommun, 2026d). This expectation is further reinforced through practical guidance, where residents are provided with detailed lists of necessary supplies such as water, food, lighting and medication, making preparedness a concrete and everyday responsibility (Norrköpings kommun, 2026e). The expectation that residents should be self-reliant for at least one week follows national guidance, but also assumes that individuals have both the ability and motivation to prepare, which may not reflect the practical challenges people face in everyday life. This expectation is also communicated in the municipal brochure, where residents are encouraged to take personal responsibility for their preparedness in order to reduce pressure on societal resources during crises (Norrköpings kommun, n.d.-b, p. 2 & 12). Compared with the national brochure, the municipal material makes this responsibility more concrete by connecting it to local crisis management capacity and to the municipality's need to prioritise support for the most vulnerable. From a risk perception perspective, this assumes that individuals perceive the risks as serious, manageable and personally relevant and therefore as something worth acting upon (Slovic, 2000, p. 233-234). If risks are instead seen as distant, unlikely or mainly handled by authorities, individuals are less likely to act on the information (Slovic, 2000, p. 394-395).

This shared-responsibility framing is not limited to a single document, but is repeated across the municipality's general preparedness information pages (Norrköpings kommun, 2026c). Here, residents are consistently reminded of their responsibility to maintain home preparedness and to stay informed through official channels such as Sveriges Radio P4 and the Swedish VMA system (Important Public Announcement system) (Norrköpings kommun, 2026c). The municipal brochure further reinforces this by highlighting the importance of relying on these channels, particularly in situations where

other forms of communication may be unavailable (Norrköpings kommun, n.d.-b, p. 4-5). Municipal communication largely follows national guidance by emphasising the same information channels through which residents are expected to remain informed. The repeated focus on this message across multiple platforms reinforces preparedness as an ongoing individual responsibility, even though practical and perceptual barriers may limit people's ability to act.

5.1.1 Governance, Coordination and Responsibility

The municipal crisis management plan describes a structured and hierarchical crisis organisation, with clearly defined roles and ways of coordinating actions (Norrköpings kommun, 2024, p. 4). The plan also highlights the municipality's geographic area responsibility. In practice, this means that the municipality is expected to coordinate local actors and ensure that the public receives clear, consistent and coordinated information during crises (Norrköpings kommun, 2024, p. 3-4). Communication is also described as central to effective crisis management, where coordinated information is expected to support both practical response and public understanding during crises (Norrköpings kommun, 2024, p. 14). National and municipal preparedness governance are closely aligned, with municipalities primarily implementing national preparedness frameworks. However, while organisational structures, responsibilities and coordination are clearly outlined, the documents pay less attention to how residents interpret and apply preparedness information in practice. Preparedness communication largely focuses on information provision.

The communication guidelines prioritise clarity, transparency and accessibility, highlighting that information should be correct, timely and easy to understand (Norrköping kommun, 2011, p. 7). This reflects an institutional focus on making information accessible, rather than on how it is interpreted or acted upon. Communication is described as strategic and proactive and as an integrated part of governance and planning (Norrköping kommun, 2011, p. 13). Yet the underlying assumption appears to be that accessible information will support appropriate behaviour. The municipal brochure reflects this assumption, as it provides residents with practical instructions and planning tools for how to prepare for different types of crises (Norrköpings kommun, n.d.-b, p. 18). This can be understood as preparedness communication primarily focusing on what residents should do, rather than how different conditions may affect their ability to act in practice. As a result, access to information alone may not be sufficient to ensure actual preparedness.

This aligns with crisis and risk communication theory, which emphasises the importance of timely and structured pre-crisis communication to reduce uncertainty (Coombs, 2019, p. 19-20). However, Coombs (2019) also highlights that communication effectiveness depends on how stakeholders interpret the message, rather than on clarity alone (Coombs, 2019, p. 3). From the perspective of risk perception, the assumption that information leads to action can be questioned. Slovic (2000) argues that risk is not something objective that individuals simply receive, but rather something that is shaped by subjective interpretation, personal experience and cultural context (Slovic, 2000, p. 392-393). Institutional clarity does not automatically translate into perceived urgency or behavioural change, highlighting a limitation in approaches that prioritise information provision over behavioural engagement. This hierarchical governance logic is also reflected in the municipality's overall security policy framework. Here, strategic coordination, clear responsibilities and following internal guidelines are presented as key elements of systematic security work (Norrköpings kommun, 2025, p. 2-3).

Overall, this is a key finding of the analysis: preparedness governance is mainly organised through formal and institutional structures that focus on coordination, control and information provision, while much of the responsibility for preparedness is placed on individual residents. At the same time, the analysed documents show limited evidence of participatory or community-based approaches that actively involve residents in

preparedness planning. The analysis therefore indicates that current preparedness governance lacks important elements of urban transformative capacity, particularly inclusive governance, participation and social learning processes (Wolfram, 2016, p. 126). This is further reinforced by the municipality's emphasis on systematic risk management and continuity planning, where preparedness is embedded in routine governance structures rather than in participatory or community-based processes (Norrköpings kommun, 2025, p. 2).

5.1.2 Inclusion, Accessibility and Trust

MSB emphasises that traditional authority communication does not reach all groups equally, particularly due to language barriers and low levels of institutional trust (MSB, 2022, p. 5). The MSB report highlights direct communication such as direct contact through trusted individuals or community networks and collaboration with local actors as effective strategies for reaching groups that are otherwise difficult to engage (MSB, 2022, p. 7). Taken together, these findings suggest that trust and local relationships play a central role in how information is received and understood. It also indicates an awareness at the national level that communication effectiveness depends on social context, not only on the information itself. This aligns with Slovic's (2000) argument that trust is a central factor shaping how risk information is interpreted and acted upon. When trust in institutions is low, people are less likely to accept or act on risk communication, even if the information is accurate (Slovic, 2000, p. 396).

The MSB report also emphasises inclusive communication through principles of universal design and multimodal communication. This means that information should be accessible from the start and communicated through multiple formats such as text, visuals and audio rather than assuming that one format is sufficient for all groups (MSB, 2022, p. 11). Approximately 20-25 percent of the population is described as having difficulties understanding traditional text-based information (MSB, 2022, p. 9). These findings challenge the assumption that written digital information alone is sufficient to ensure preparedness across diverse populations. This also aligns with crisis communication theory's focus on audience-centred communication, where messages need to take into account how residents access, understand and act on information (Coombs, 2019, p. 19-20). In the municipal material, some of these principles are visible in a more limited way. The local brochure uses concrete language, visual structure and step-by-step guidance and it addresses different risks and support points such as temporary support centres (trygghetspunkter), which may make preparedness information more concrete for residents (Norrköpings kommun, n.d.-b, p. 13 & 18). At the same time, the material still primarily relies on written communication and provides a limited range of more dialogical or trust-building approaches of the kind highlighted as important in the MSB report (MSB, 2022, p. 7 & 15).

However, while these principles emphasise the importance of trust, accessibility and multiple communication formats, the municipal material analysed in this study primarily relies on written and information-based communication. Although information is made available through different channels, the material shows limited evidence of more interactive or community-based approaches aimed at engaging residents or how information is understood and used in practice. Inclusive communication involves not only making information accessible, but also addressing how trust, interpretation and everyday conditions shape whether people act on it. This points to a limitation in communication approaches that primarily focus on information provision rather than engagement.

The importance of trust is further reinforced across the analysed documents, where effective preparedness communication is described as dependent on credibility, transparency and institutional legitimacy. Communication is described as effective only when trust exists between authorities and residents (MSB, 2022, p. 15). Transparency regarding risks and uncertainties is framed as necessary to prevent misinformation and increase the likelihood

that people follow official recommendations (MSB, 2022, p. 16). Similarly, municipal communication guidelines emphasise openness and professionalism in media relations (Norrköping kommun, 2011, p. 25). The municipal brochure also reflects this indirectly by encouraging residents to rely on official sources, remain critical of misinformation and follow verified crisis information during emergencies (Norrköpings kommun, n.d.-b, p. 5 & 17).

This emphasis on transparency aligns with Slovic's (2000) argument that openness about uncertainty can strengthen credibility and reduce suspicion, whereas limiting information may increase distrust (Slovic, 2000, p. 396). This highlights the importance of transparent and honest communication, where engaging residents in an open dialogue may be more effective than simply providing information that lacks clarity or accuracy. Moreover, the recognition that misinformation and emotional reactions influence public behaviour reflects a broader understanding that communication processes can increase or reduce how risks are perceived (Slovic, 2000, p. 234-235). The analysed material suggests that preparedness is not only a technical issue, but also a relational one, shaped by credibility and how legitimate the information is perceived to be.

5.1.3 Information Provision and the Responsibility to Act

Several documents indicate that knowledge alone is insufficient to produce behavioural change. The MSB report highlights a gap between intention and action, showing that individuals often fail to act despite being aware of risks (MSB, 2022, p. 13). The COM-B model provides a framework for understanding behaviour by emphasising that three conditions must be present simultaneously for action to occur: capability, opportunity and motivation (MSB, 2022, p. 14). Capability refers to individuals having the necessary knowledge and skills to act, opportunity concerns external conditions such as available resources, infrastructure and social support, and motivation includes both conscious intentions and routine or emotional drivers of behaviour (MSB, 2022, p. 14 & 17). Together, these components highlight that behaviour is not only a matter of knowing what to do, but also of being able and willing to do it in a given context.

While authorities provide detailed preparedness information, responsibility for acting on this information is largely placed on individual residents. This assumes that individuals have both access to preparedness information and the motivation, capability and opportunity to maintain preparedness over time. This perspective complements risk perception theory by illustrating that even when risks are recognised, this does not necessarily lead to action as emotional, social and practical barriers may prevent individuals from acting (Slovic, 2000, p. 233-234). Despite this understanding, the practical preparedness advice provided in municipal and national materials largely consists of checklists and step-by-step guidance, which primarily focus on what individuals should do rather than how they are supported in actually doing it. This is evident in the municipal brochure, which provides step-by-step guidance on how residents should prepare, including storing water, preparing crisis kits and developing personal crisis plans (Norrköpings kommun, n.d.-b, p. 18-19).

Municipal communication translates national preparedness guidance into practical checklists and planning tools directed at individuals and households. In line with national guidance, residents are instructed to store water, food and alternative heat sources (MSB, 2024, p. 15). Similar recommendations are also provided in municipal preparedness material through detailed crisis supply lists (Norrköpings kommun, 2026e). Residents are also encouraged to develop household crisis plans and regularly maintain their preparedness over time (Norrköpings kommun, 2026b). This frames preparedness as an ongoing individual responsibility rather than a one-time action. While these instructions are detailed and practical, they primarily focus on what individuals should do, rather than how different conditions may affect their ability to implement these measures or the support available to

help residents maintain preparedness in practice. In this way, the municipal material makes national preparedness guidance more concrete, but largely repeats the same expectations of individual responsibility rather than changing them. A central tension within institutional preparedness communication is that behavioural complexity is acknowledged in principle, while preparedness communication in practice remains focused on information provision and individual responsibility. If individuals perceive crises as unlikely or primarily managed by authorities, preparedness may be seen as less important despite available guidance (Slovic, 2000, p. 394-395). This finding supports previous research by Levac et al. (2012), which shows that access to preparedness information does not necessarily translate into action, as individuals may face motivational and practical barriers to preparedness (Levac et al., 2012, p. 730).

However, this governance logic is not unique to preparedness communication. Research on sustainable urban development shows that even when policy ambitions are transformative, implementation is often limited by institutional structures, political and economic pressures and established practices (Filion et al., 2015, p. 210-211). This suggests that even clearly defined preparedness ambitions may remain limited if institutional structures reinforce hierarchical and expert-driven forms of governance. From the perspective of urban transformative capacity, strengthening preparedness would require inclusive governance arrangements, social learning and active involvement of residents in shaping resilience practices (Wolfram, 2016, p. 126-127). Such an approach would move beyond information provision and instead involve residents in actively shaping preparedness. However, the analysed documents mainly present residents as passive receivers of predefined guidance rather than involving them as active participants in preparedness planning. Preparedness governance in the studied case largely operates within an informational and centralised framework, where responsibility is placed on residents, while strategic direction and decision-making remain institutionalised.

5.1.4 Summary

Overall, the document analysis demonstrates that preparedness is institutionally framed as a shared responsibility between the state, the municipality and individual residents. Across the analysed documents, preparedness is presented not only as a practical necessity but also as a moral and civic responsibility connected to national resilience and total defence. Communication is positioned as a central tool for achieving preparedness, primarily through the provision of clear, coordinated and accessible information. At the same time, the analysis shows that preparedness communication remains largely an information-driven and top-down approach. Although behavioural factors such as trust, accessibility and motivation are acknowledged in some policy documents, preparedness is still primarily approached through the provision of information and practical guidance directed at individuals and households. The analysis further suggests that institutional actors largely assume that residents, when provided with accessible and reliable information, will interpret risks appropriately and act accordingly. However, crisis communication research emphasises that communication outcomes depend on interpretation rather than message clarity alone (Coombs, 2019, p. 3-4). Risk perception research similarly highlights that preparedness behaviour is shaped by trust, subjective interpretations and perceived control rather than by technical risk assessments (Slovic, 2000, p. 233-234).

Municipal communication largely reproduces national preparedness frameworks while adapting them to local risks and conditions. Taken together, the analysed policy documents, communication materials and preparedness guidelines indicate a broader institutional logic in which responsibility is decentralised to residents, while governance and communication remain highly coordinated and institutionalised. This provides an analytical foundation for examining how residents interpret preparedness expectations and whether institutional assumptions about preparedness are reflected in practice.

5.2 Residents' Perceived Preparedness

The survey results provide empirical insights into how residents in Norrköping perceive, interpret and act upon preparedness communication. While the document analysis examined how preparedness is institutionally framed by national and municipal actors, this section analyses whether these institutional expectations are reflected in residents' own perceptions, preparedness practices and intended actions. A total of 94 respondents participated in the survey, forming the primary empirical basis for analysing perceived preparedness, risk perception and intended behaviour. The respondents consisted of 52.1% women (49 respondents) and 47.9% men (45 respondents). Those who participated in the survey were distributed across several age groups, with the largest group being 25-34 years (38.3%), followed by 45-54 (18.1%) and 35-44 (17.0%). Smaller groups included 18-24 (11.7%), 55-64 (8.5%) and 65+ (6.4%). This demographic distribution is relevant for interpreting the results, as perceptions of risk and preparedness may vary depending on factors such as age and gender.

The results reveal a consistent pattern, while awareness of crisis preparedness is relatively common, this awareness does not translate into practical preparedness, confidence or structured planning. This section therefore analyses preparedness not only as a matter of exposure to information, but as a process shaped by interpretation, trust, perceived responsibility and everyday constraints. To further explore this pattern, the analysis draws on both the structured survey responses and the scenario-based answers, highlighting how preparedness is expressed at different levels, ranging from general awareness to actual capability and action. This makes it possible to identify not only what residents know but how they understand, evaluate and apply preparedness in practice. The section also builds on the document analysis by examining whether the institutional assumptions identified in municipal and national preparedness communication are reflected in residents' perceptions, knowledge and reported preparedness. More specifically, the document analysis showed that preparedness is communicated as a shared responsibility between institutions and residents, while at the same time placing significant responsibility on individuals to prepare for several days, preferably up to one week, without external support (Norrköpings kommun, n.d.-b, p. 2). All scaled survey questions were measured on a 1-10 scale, where higher values indicate higher levels of agreement, perceived clarity, trust or preparedness.

5.2.1 Exposure to preparedness information

The survey results show that 78.7% of respondents have been exposed to crisis preparedness information, but that this exposure is uneven both in terms of communication channels and engagement. Of the 94 respondents living in Norrköping municipality, 78.7% reported that they had encountered preparedness-related information during the past 12 months. This suggests that preparedness communication has a relatively broad reach. However, a closer examination reveals important differences between passive exposure and active engagement. While 66.0% of respondents reported that they had received the national preparedness brochure *Om krisen eller kriget kommer* (MSB, 2024), 11.7% stated that they had received the brochure but had not read it. In addition, 10.6% reported that they had not received the brochure at all, while 11.7% were unsure. A disconnect therefore exists between the distribution of preparedness information and actual engagement with its content. The remaining respondents reported that they had not received it at all or were unsure. This indicates that distribution alone does not ensure that information is understood or used. This is particularly significant in relation to the document analysis. Both the national and municipal brochures are presented as key tools for translating preparedness expectations into everyday practice (MSB, 2024, p. 6). The survey results, however, indicate that receiving the brochure does not necessarily lead to engagement with its content.

A closer examination of the data also reveals differences across age groups in relation to engagement with the brochure. Among respondents aged 45-54, four out of seventeen respondents (23.5%) reported that they had received the brochure but had not read it. In the

55-64 age group, four out of eight respondents (50.0%) reported the same. In comparison, this response was less common among younger respondents, with one out of eleven respondents aged 18-24 (9.1%) and two out of thirty-six respondents aged 25-34 (5.6%) indicating that they had not engaged with the brochure despite receiving it. No respondents in the 35-44 or 65+ groups reported this, although this may be due to the limited number of responses. These findings suggest that limited engagement occurs across several age groups, although no clear pattern can be identified. This indicates that the challenge is not only whether information reaches individuals, but whether it is perceived as relevant and worth engaging with.In addition, only 16.0% reported receiving additional preparedness-related information directly to their home beyond the national brochure. Preparedness information was instead primarily encountered through indirect communication channels such as social media and television. This may reflect differences in how individuals prioritise preparedness information in everyday life, rather than differences in access alone.

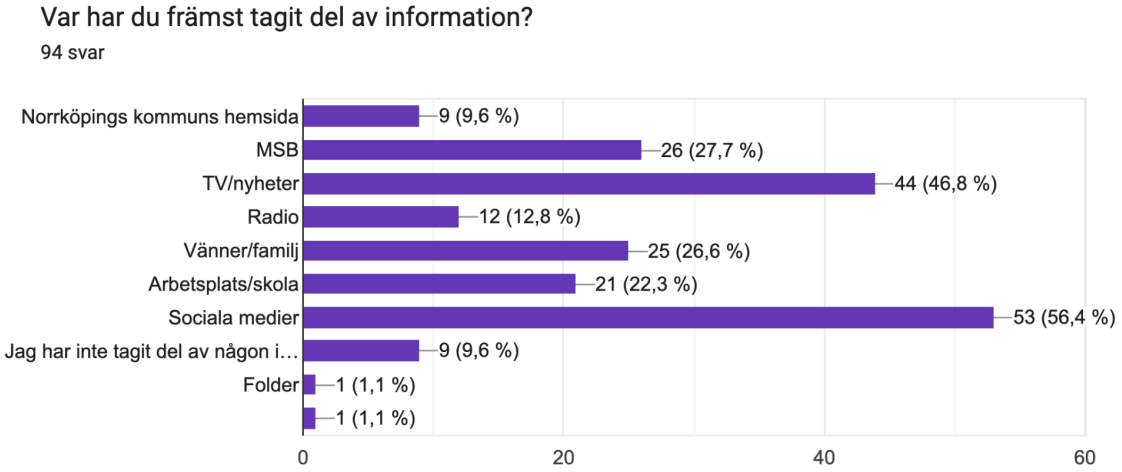


Figure 1. How respondents receive preparedness information (94 responses).

As shown in Figure 1, the results indicate that preparedness information is most commonly encountered through indirect channels such as social media and television. The municipal website was mentioned less frequently as a source of information. A closer examination of the data also reveals differences across age groups. Among respondents aged 18-34, 66.7% reported encountering preparedness information through social media, whereas respondents aged 55 and above reported significantly lower use of social media and a stronger reliance on traditional media such as television 60%. This suggests that preparedness communication reaches different age groups through different communication channels, which may influence how information is received and understood. It may also make information more spread out, as it comes from different places without one clear source. From a communication perspective, this may reduce the consistency and clarity of preparedness information, as different channels may present information in different ways. Research shows that communication effectiveness depends not only on message content but also on whether information is delivered through channels that are trusted and regularly used by the target audience (Tam et al., 2018, p. 7-8).

This variation in communication channels becomes particularly significant when compared with the document analysis, where preparedness communication is framed as structured, coordinated and broadly accessible. The document analysis shows that residents are repeatedly directed to official channels such as Sveriges Radio P4, VMA and municipal preparedness information. This suggests that communication is presented as coordinated and consistent across different platforms (Norrköpings kommun, 2026c). The survey results show that residents encounter preparedness information in a more uneven and less

structured way. While official documents describe communication as coordinated and accessible, the results suggest that information is instead spread across multiple sources. Residents appear to interpret preparedness information as separate messages from different sources, rather than as one clear system. The use of multiple communication channels may also affect how residents engage with official preparedness information. Previous research shows that citizens do not always actively engage with official communication channels, partly because they are uncertain which sources to trust or how to access relevant information (Hong et al., 2018, p. 1036). This finding is supported by research showing that preparedness information is often distributed through multiple actors and communication channels, where there is no guarantee that information reaches all residents effectively, creating uncertainty in how information is received and used (Kaneberg, 2018, p. 22 & 24).

5.2.2 Clarity and Trust

Although a large proportion of respondents had encountered preparedness information, their evaluation of its clarity and reliability was relatively low rather than high. On a scale from 1 to 10, the average rating for how clearly the information explains "what I should do" was 5.95. As shown in Figure 2, trust in whether authorities and municipalities provide correct information before and during crises was rated at 5.30. These results suggest that preparedness communication is neither strongly trusted nor strongly distrusted, but instead reflects a mid-range level of trust.

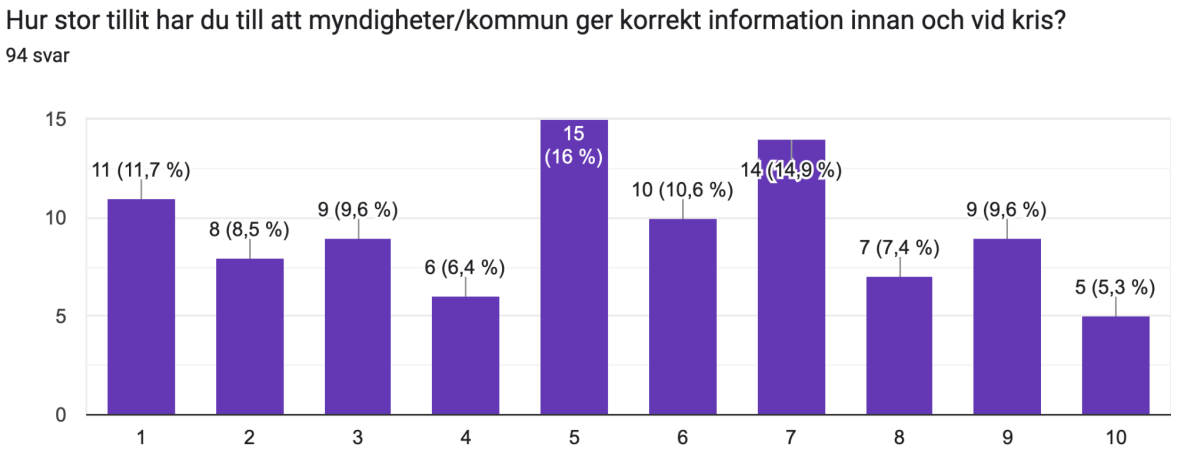


Figure 2. Respondents' level of trust in whether authorities and municipalities provide correct information before and during crises (94 responses).

A closer examination of the data also reveals variations across age groups and gender. Respondents aged 55 and above tended to rate both clarity and trust higher, with average scores of 6.4 for clarity and 5.8 for trust. Respondents aged 18-34 reported lower levels, with average clarity scores of 5.4 and trust levels of 5.0. Differences can also be observed between gender. Female respondents reported slightly higher levels of both perceived clarity 6.1 and trust 5.5, compared to male respondents who reported somewhat lower values, 5.7 for clarity and 5.1 for trust. These patterns suggest that views on preparedness communication vary depending on demographic factors such as age and gender. This variation shows that preparedness communication is not understood in the same way by everyone, but differs depending on individuals' contexts and characteristics. Older respondents tend to report higher trust and clearer understanding, which may reflect greater trust in institutions or familiarity with traditional communication formats. Younger respondents on the other hand report lower levels, which may indicate a need for more targeted and relevant communication.

This evaluation is important because it indicates that the presence of information does not necessarily translate into a strong sense of guidance or confidence among residents. The open-ended responses provide further insight into this pattern. A large number of respondents expressed a need for more concrete, practical and locally relevant information. In total, 66 respondents highlighted the need for clearer information, while 38 respondents specifically requested more concrete instructions on what to do in different crisis situations. Similarly, 38 respondents emphasised the importance of locally relevant information, such as where to go or how crises would affect them in their surroundings. These respondents expressed a need for clearer, situation-specific guidance that relates directly to their local context. Others highlighted uncertainty about how general recommendations should be translated into everyday action. Together, these responses suggest that clarity is not only about providing accurate information, but also about ensuring that it is perceived as practical and relevant.

An important analytical observation is that this mid-level evaluation appears to coexist with a clear demand for improved communication. While clarity was rated at 5.95, many respondents still expressed a need for more concrete and locally relevant information. Even when information is perceived as relatively clear, residents may still experience it as insufficiently useful in practice. In other words, respondents do not necessarily reject the information, but indicate that it does not fully meet their needs in terms of practical guidance. This highlights a key finding of the analysis, as information may be understood in general terms without necessarily being perceived as sufficiently practical or actionable in everyday contexts. In other words, even when information is available it may not be experienced as useful if it does not clearly answer the question "what should I do in my situation?". Research on crisis communication highlights that information must be tailored to the needs and contexts of different audiences in order to influence behaviour (Steelman & McCaffrey, 2012, p. 688). This need for more concrete and locally relevant guidance is also reflected in several open-ended responses. For example, one respondent stated:

"I would need clearer instructions about what to actually do and where to go."

When compared with the document analysis, this finding shows a mismatch between institutional assumptions and residents' experiences. In the municipal communication guidelines, crisis information is described as something that should be correct, timely and easy to understand, suggesting that clarity is treated as a central condition for effective communication (Norrköping kommun, 2011, p. 7). The survey results however, show that many residents do not experience the information as sufficiently concrete or useful in practice. This indicates that clarity in communication does not automatically translate into clarity in action. Such responses highlight that preparedness communication is not primarily lacking in availability, but in practical relevance. This also reflects a broader limitation identified in the document analysis. Although communication is made available through multiple formats, it is not always adapted to how different groups understand and interpret information (MSB, 2022, p. 11). The survey responses support this by showing that residents continue to request information that is more concrete and easier to apply in everyday situations. This reinforces findings in previous research showing that information alone is not sufficient to influence behaviour and that effective communication must take into account how individuals perceive and interpret risk (Steelman & McCaffrey, 2012, p. 685-686).

5.2.3 Risk Perception

Respondents' perception of risk appears to be relatively high compared to their perceived preparedness. When asked how likely it is that a serious societal disruption could occur in Norrköping within the next five years, respondents gave an average rating of 6.19.

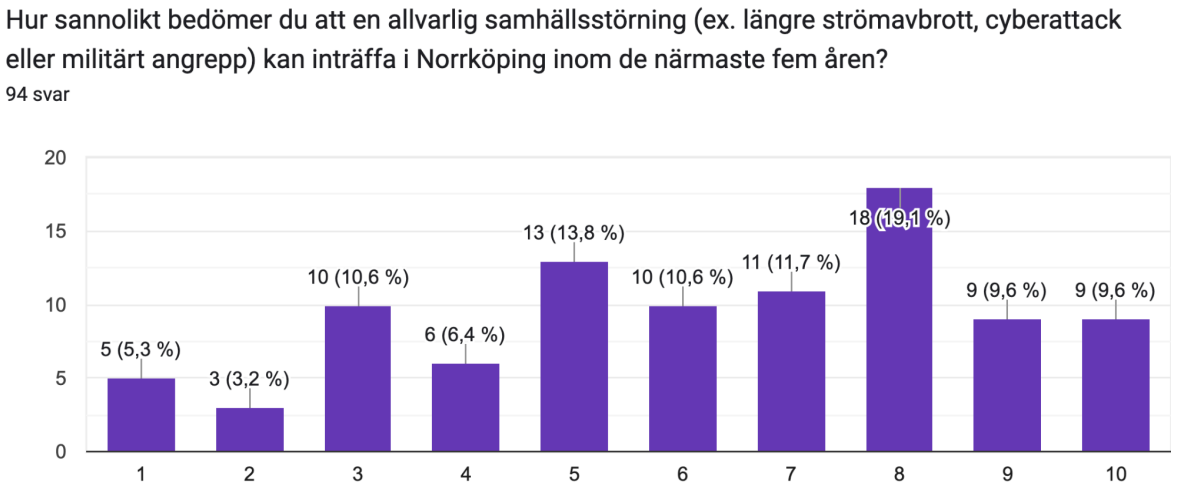


Figure 3. Perceived likelihood of a serious societal disruption occurring in Norrköping within the next five years (94 responses).

This indicates that many respondents consider crisis scenarios such as power outages, cyberattacks or military threats to be relatively likely rather than unlikely. A closer examination of the data reveals variations across both age groups and gender. Respondents aged 55 and above reported higher perceived likelihood of a serious societal disruption, with average scores around 6.6, compared to respondents aged 18-34, who reported lower values 5.7. Respondents aged 35-54 fell in between these groups, with a score of 6.2. Differences can also be observed between genders. Female respondents reported a higher perceived likelihood 6.4 compared to male respondents 5.9. However, these differences are not large, indicating that while variation exists, overall perceptions remain broadly similar across groups. These patterns may suggest that higher risk perception among older respondents and women is linked to differences in perceived vulnerability, experience or awareness of societal risks. This variation is important because risk perception can influence whether residents see preparedness as necessary and personally relevant. However, higher perceived risk does not necessarily translate into higher levels of preparedness (Tam et al., 2018, p. 8-9).

This finding is significant because it suggests that respondents are not dismissing the possibility of crisis. Instead, there is a general awareness that disruptions may occur, reflected in a relatively high perceived likelihood of 6.19. However as shown in Figures 4 and 5, this awareness does not appear to translate into a comparable level of preparedness. Respondents rated their confidence in knowing what to do if they heard a warning signal outdoors at 4.35 and their preparedness for a crisis lasting more than two days at 4.11.

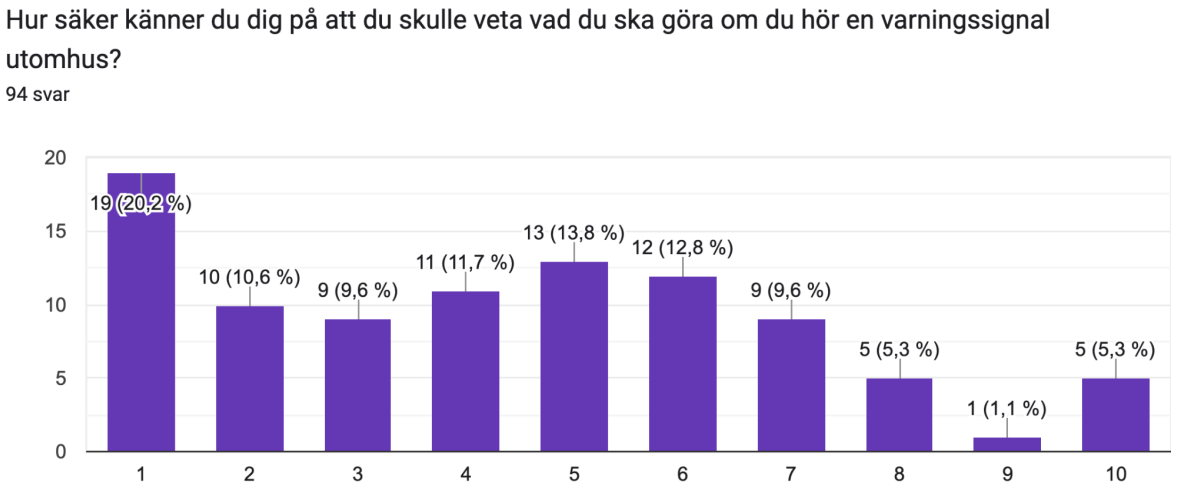


Figure 4. Confidence in knowing what to do when hearing a warning signal outdoors (94 responses).

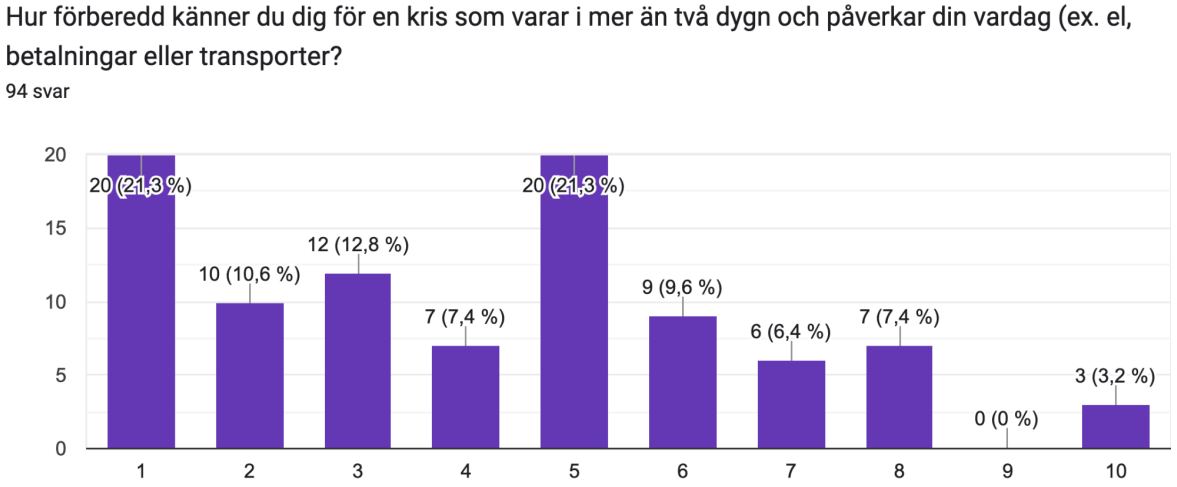


Figure 5. Perceived preparedness for a crisis lasting more than two days and affecting everyday life (94 responses).

The contrast between relatively high perceived risk and lower perceived preparedness suggests a disconnect between recognising risk and feeling capable of responding to it. The results align with previous research showing that risk perception alone is insufficient to generate preparedness behaviour. Individuals may recognise that a risk exists, but still lack the motivation, resources or confidence required to prepare for it (Ning et al., 2021, p. 5-6). In this study, respondents' relatively high risk perception combined with low perceived preparedness indicates that awareness is present, but that it is not effectively translated into action or confidence.

A key analytical tension emerges between relatively high risk perception and low perceived preparedness. While institutional communication assumes that awareness of risk will lead to preparedness, the survey results suggest that recognising risk does not generate action. This finding supports behavioural perspectives on preparedness, which emphasise

that risk perception alone is insufficient to motivate preparedness behaviour without matching levels of self-efficacy and perceived capability (Ning et al., 2021, p. 5-6). Similarly, research highlights that individuals evaluate risks not only based on likelihood, but also in relation to perceived control and personal relevance, which influences whether awareness translates into action (Slovic, 2000, p. 233-234). This challenges the institutional logic identified in the document analysis. There, residents are addressed as actors who are expected to prepare in advance for disruptions such as power outages, suggesting that these risks are framed as sufficiently meaningful and practical to motivate preparation (Norrköpings kommun, n.d.-b, p. 6). This is a key finding because it shows that the individual responsibility emphasised in the document analysis is not fully matched by residents' perceived preparedness or confidence in action. Although residents recognise that crises may occur, they do not necessarily feel prepared or capable of fulfilling the responsibility that institutional communication places on them.

5.2.4 Awareness and Action

The survey results reveal a gap between general awareness of preparedness concepts and knowledge of how to act. While 88.3% of respondents stated that they know what the warning signal "Hesa Fredrik" is, this primarily reflects recognition of the signal rather than an understanding of what it means in practice (see Figure 6 below).

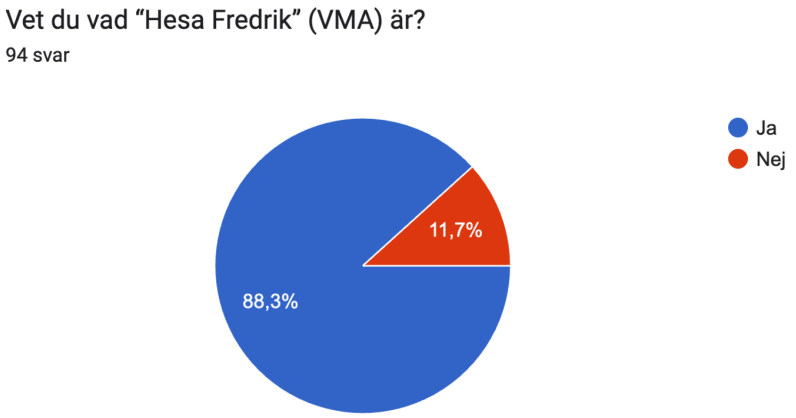


Figure 6. Awareness of the warning signal "Hesa Fredrik" (94 responses).

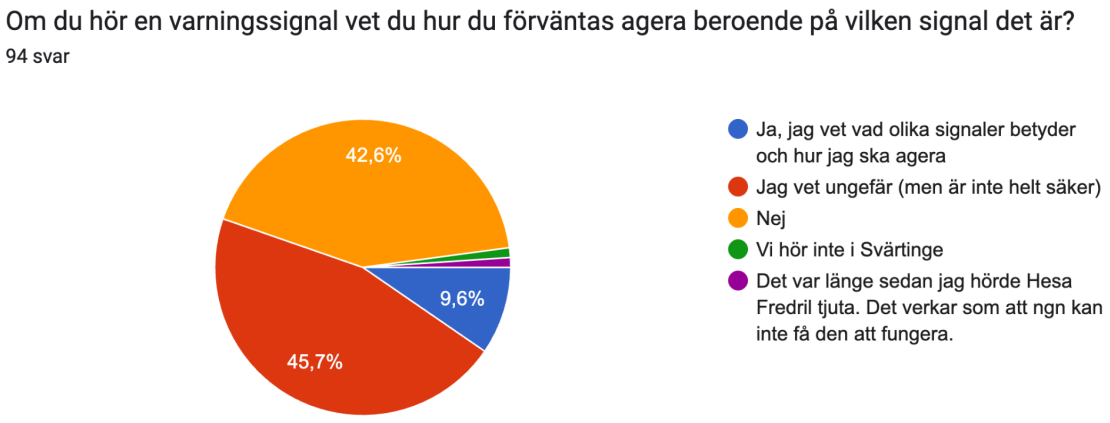


Figure 7. Knowledge of how to respond to different warning signals (94 responses).

However, as shown in Figure 7, this awareness does not translate into a comparable level of understanding the different signals. Only 9.6% reported that they know what the different signals mean and how they should respond in practice. A large proportion 45.7% indicated that they "approximately" know, while 42.6% stated that they do not know, the result shows uncertainty regarding appropriate actions. A similar pattern is visible in Figure 8, which shows that knowledge of shelter locations is also limited. This further supports the gap between general awareness and practical knowledge.

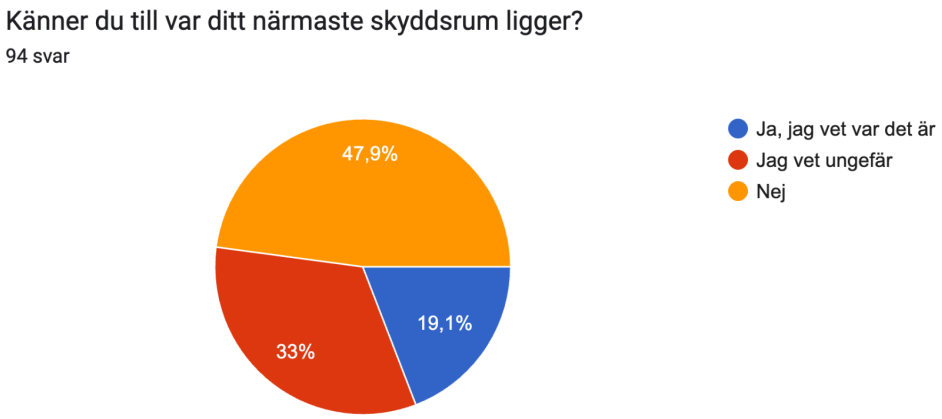


Figure 8. Knowledge of the location of the nearest shelter (94 responses).

As shown in Figure 8, nearly half of respondents 47.9% reported that they do not know where their nearest shelter is and only 19.1% stated that they know. In addition, respondents were asked whether the statement "*In Sweden, you must go to a fixed shelter if something happens*" was true or false, where the correct answer is false (MSB, 2024, p. 20-21). A significant proportion 30.9% answered incorrectly, indicating that misunderstandings about basic preparedness are relatively common. Taken together, these findings suggest that awareness does not necessarily translate into functional or actionable knowledge. Respondents may recognise preparedness concepts, but lack the understanding required to act effectively in a crisis.

A closer examination of the data reveals some variation across gender and age groups, although the overall pattern remains consistent. In terms of gender, differences are relatively small. Among female respondents, 89.8% reported that they know what the warning signal "Hesa Fredrik" is, compared to 86.7% of male respondents. While this indicates slightly higher recognition among women, both groups demonstrate similarly limited knowledge regarding how to interpret the signals and how to act. For example, only 10.2% of female respondents and 8.9% of male respondents reported that they know what the different signals mean and how they should respond. This suggests that the gap between awareness and actionable knowledge is not gender-specific. Differences across age groups are somewhat more pronounced. For example, 81.8% of respondents aged 18-24 reported that they know what "Hesa Fredrik" is, compared to 93.8% among those aged 35-44 and 100% among respondents aged 65 and above. However, this higher level of awareness does not necessarily translate into a stronger understanding of how to act. In most age groups, only a small proportion reported that they know how to interpret the signals and act accordingly, although this proportion is somewhat higher among the oldest respondents. The majority across all age groups indicated uncertainty.

A similar pattern is visible in relation to knowledge of shelters. Among respondents

aged 18-24, 36.4% reported that they know where their nearest shelter is, while this decreases in several other groups, such as 16.7% among respondents aged 25-34 and 11.8% among those aged 45-54. At the same time, many respondents across all age groups reported that they do not know where their nearest shelter is, with the highest proportion 62.5% among those aged 55-64. This suggests that location-specific knowledge remains limited regardless of age. Overall, these patterns indicate that some demographic differences exist, particularly in relation to age. However, the observed gap appears to be structural rather than demographic, affecting residents across groups.

These findings suggest that recognition of key terms such as Hesa Fredrik does not necessarily mean functional knowledge. Individuals may be familiar with concepts such as warning signals or shelters without knowing how to act in practice. This difference is crucial, as effective preparedness requires not only awareness but also practical knowledge. Previous research shows that individuals often overestimate their preparedness despite lacking essential knowledge or plans, highlighting a gap between perceived and actual preparedness (Kohn et al., 2012, p. 227). This suggests that awareness of preparedness concepts may create a false sense of being prepared. This becomes particularly important in relation to document analysis, where warning systems and preparedness concepts are communicated as central elements of public preparedness. The document analysis shows that the municipal brochure highlights warning systems and official information channels as practical sources of guidance in crisis situations (Norrköpings kommun, n.d.-b, p. 4-5). This suggests that residents are expected not only to recognise these signals, but also to know how to act on them. The survey results indicate that this expectation is only partly reflected in practice.

5.2.5 Practical Preparedness

Preparedness is uneven and not fully developed, as respondents often report having some basic resources, but lack more comprehensive preparation and planning. The majority of respondents reported having access to flashlights or headlamps 64.9%, batteries 55.3% and some form of long-lasting food 45.7%. These items are relatively low-cost, easy to obtain and easy to store for long periods, which may partly explain why many respondents reported having them. It is also possible that some of these items were already present in households for everyday use rather than purchased specifically for preparedness purposes. However, fewer respondents reported having more important resources recommended in preparedness guidelines. Only around one-fifth of respondents reported having stored water for at least three days 21.3%, a battery-powered or crank radio 21.3% or important documents collected in one place 20.2%. In addition, a notable group of respondents 26.6% reported that they had not prepared anything at home.

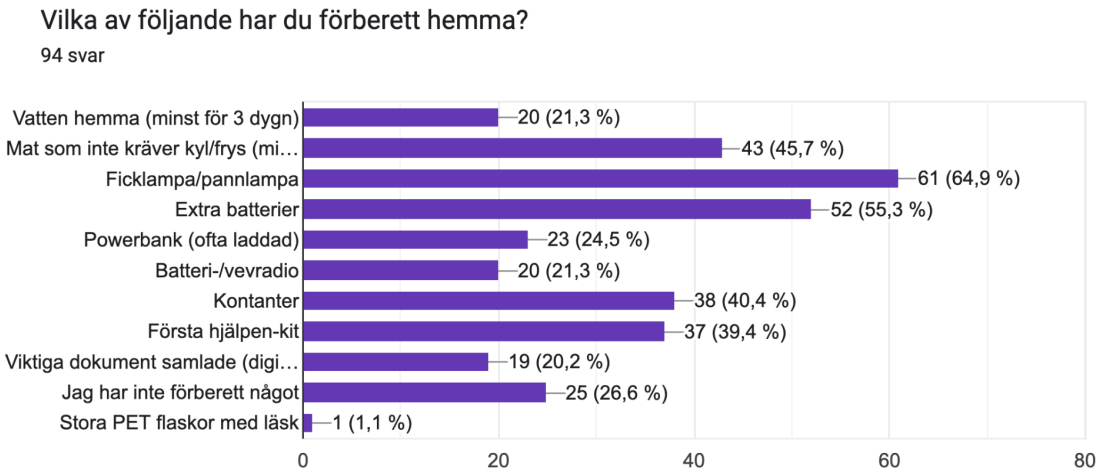


Figure 9. Reported household preparedness measures among respondents (94 responses).

Many respondents appear to have taken some steps, but not enough to be self-sufficient during a longer crisis. People have taken some preparedness steps, but these are not part of a clear or structured plan. Instead, preparedness is uneven and mainly consists of simple measures rather than more long-term preparations. This suggests that some respondents may perceive themselves as relatively prepared despite lacking key resources or structured preparedness plans, which reflects findings by Kohn et al. (2012, p. 227). This pattern reflects previous research showing that many households lack emergency supplies and preparedness plans and may not fully understand what preparedness involves in practice, including how to prepare emergency kits or develop crisis plans (Kohn et al., 2012, p. 226 & 228). This may reflect practical constraints, motivation or perceived necessity in everyday life. It also suggests that preparedness communication is not fully translated into behavioural change (Levac et al., 2012, p. 725 & 730). In relation to the document analysis, this is significant because municipal and national materials clearly communicate that residents are expected to manage basic needs for several days, preferably up to one week. The document analysis shows that the municipal material makes this expectation concrete through lists of recommended supplies such as water, food, lighting, hygiene products and medication (Norrköpings kommun, 2026e). The survey results, however, show that these resources are only partly available in households. This points to difficulties in translating communicated standards into actual civic preparedness. In addition to material resources, preparedness also involves planning and the ability to act. As shown in Figure 10, a large proportion of respondents reported that they do not have a plan for how to act in a crisis.



Figure 10. Whether respondents have a plan for how to act in a crisis or war (94 responses).

A particularly clear indication of limited preparedness is that 70.2% of respondents reported that they do not have a plan for what to do in the event of a crisis or war, while only 29.8% indicated that they do. This suggests that preparedness is not only limited in terms of resources, but also in terms of structured planning. The findings reinforce the broader pattern identified throughout the analysis, while awareness of crisis preparedness is relatively high it is not translated into concrete or planned action. This pattern suggests that preparedness behaviour is shaped not only by knowledge, but by practical constraints and prioritisation in everyday life. This aligns with research showing that households are often partly prepared and lack the resources needed to manage a longer crisis (Levac et al., 2012, p. 727-728). This indicates that preparedness is often implemented as isolated actions rather than as a clear and long-term strategy.

5.2.6 Perceived preparedness and self-efficacy

Respondents' perceived ability to act in crisis situations is generally low. Respondents rated their ability to act when hearing a warning signal outdoors at 4.35, while their preparedness for a crisis lasting more than two days was rated at 4.11. These relatively low scores indicate limited confidence in personal preparedness. This is particularly significant when considered in relation to respondents' relatively high risk perception. While many respondents believe that a crisis is likely, they do not feel confident in their ability to respond effectively. This suggests a lack of self-efficacy, which is a key factor in preparedness behaviour. Some variation can be observed across demographic groups, although the overall pattern remains consistent. Male respondents report slightly higher confidence in their ability to act, with scores of 4.60 compared to 4.12 among female respondents. A similar pattern is visible in perceived preparedness for a longer crisis, where men report 4.44 compared to 3.80 among women. Younger respondents aged 18-24 report the lowest levels of perceived ability to act, with scores of 3.27, while respondents aged 65 and above report higher confidence, with scores of 5.00. However, this pattern is not entirely consistent across all measures, as perceived preparedness for a longer crisis remains relatively low across most age groups. Overall, despite some demographic variation, confidence levels remain limited across all groups. Low self-efficacy is not limited to a specific demographic category, but rather reflects a broader pattern among respondents.

Self-efficacy refers to an individual's belief in their own ability to take actions required to manage a situation. Research shows that preparedness behaviour is strongly influenced by self-efficacy and that individuals who lack confidence in their ability to act are less likely to prepare or respond effectively (Tan et al., 2024, p. 5-6). In this study, the low levels of perceived preparedness suggest that many respondents do not feel capable of translating preparedness information into action. This reinforces the importance of self-efficacy as a key factor in preparedness behaviour, where individuals' belief in their ability to act determines whether awareness leads to action. Compared with the document analysis, this finding suggests that while individuals are expected to take responsibility, they do not feel equally capable of acting on it. This is particularly clear when compared to the document analysis. The municipal brochure not only encourages residents to stay informed, but also to prepare crisis kits, make plans and take practical steps in advance (Norrköpings kommun, n.d.-b, p. 18-19). While preparedness communication assumes that residents can prepare and act, many respondents do not feel confident in their own ability to do so. This can be understood in relation to risk perception theory, which highlights that individuals' responses to risk are shaped not only by awareness, but also by perceived control and capability (Slovic, 2000, p. 233-234). From a crisis communication perspective, this suggests that providing information alone is not sufficient to support preparedness, as communication must also strengthen individuals' confidence in their ability to act (Coombs, 2019, p. 19-20). This highlights a key challenge in preparedness communication, where expectations of individual responsibility are not matched by support for individuals' ability to act.

5.2.7 Responsibility

The survey results indicate variation in how respondents perceive responsibility for preparedness. While 47.9% of respondents stated that they themselves have the main responsibility for managing the first days of a crisis, others described responsibility as shared 27.7% or primarily belonging to the state or public authorities 18.1%. This distribution suggests that messages about individual responsibility are understood differently by respondents. While nearly half of respondents consider themselves responsible, a large proportion still expect support from authorities or view preparedness as a shared responsibility. This indicates that responsibility is understood in different ways, rather than as a clear or generally accepted concept. An important analytical observation is that the acceptance of personal responsibility does not appear to be matched by an equally high level of practical preparedness. While 47.9% of respondents stated that they themselves have the

main responsibility for coping during the first days of a crisis, earlier results in the survey indicate limited individual preparedness, low perceived preparedness and low confidence in knowing how to act. In other words, respondents may recognise that preparedness is their own responsibility, while still lacking the resources, confidence or routines required to fulfil that responsibility in practice. Tensions therefore emerge between the responsibility assigned to residents and their actual capability to fulfil that responsibility in practice.

From a theoretical perspective, this variation is important because perceptions of responsibility and control influence how individuals respond to risk and preparedness (Slovic, 2000, p. 394-395). If individuals perceive crises as primarily managed by authorities, they may be less likely to take personal action. Research on risk perception highlights that individuals' behaviour is shaped by how they interpret responsibility and control in relation to risk (Slovic, 2000, p. 394-395). When compared with the document analysis, the variation in perceived responsibility reflects a clear misalignment between institutional expectations and individual interpretations. While municipal communication consistently frames preparedness as an individual responsibility, the survey results indicate that this message is not fully adopted by all residents. At the same time, the document analysis also showed that preparedness is framed as a shared responsibility between institutions and residents (Norrköpings kommun, 2026d). This may help explain why respondents do not interpret responsibility in the same way. The survey results show that responsibility is not simply communicated to residents, but is interpreted in relation to trust, expectations of the welfare state and perceived control over crisis situations. This supports research showing that perceptions of responsibility are closely linked to trust in institutions and influence whether individuals take personal preparedness measures (Chen et al., 2019, p. 5 & 8).

5.2.8 Summary

Overall, the survey results indicate that residents in Norrköping are generally aware of crisis preparedness and recognise the possibility of societal disruption. Exposure to preparedness information is relatively high and many respondents demonstrate familiarity with central preparedness concepts and risks. However, this awareness is not reflected in equally high levels of preparedness, planning or confidence in action. The findings instead reveal a consistent disconnect between awareness, perceived responsibility and practical preparedness. Although many respondents recognise individual responsibility for preparedness, this responsibility is not matched by corresponding levels of practical capability or long-term planning. This is important in relation to the document analysis, which showed that institutional preparedness communication expects residents to prepare, stay informed and act on official guidance. The survey results instead suggest that these expectations are only partly reflected in practice.

Taken together, the findings suggest that preparedness communication has been more effective in increasing awareness than in supporting residents in translating preparedness into concrete preparedness practices. This aligns with research showing that information alone does not necessarily lead to preparedness action, as behaviour is shaped by motivation, capability and practical barriers (MSB, 2022, p. 14). Previous research has similarly shown that awareness and access to information do not automatically translate into preparedness behaviour (Levac et al., 2012, p. 730). From a risk perception perspective, this can also be understood through the role of trust, perceived control and personal relevance in shaping whether individuals act on risk information (Slovic, 2000, p. 233-234). When viewed in relation to the document analysis, the survey results point to a structural mismatch between institutional communication, individual perception and practical action.

5.3 Intended Actions in Crisis Scenarios

The following section focuses on scenario-based responses, examining how respondents describe their intended actions in specific crisis situations. The scenario-based responses

provide a deeper understanding of how residents translate preparedness into intended action under constrained conditions. While the previous section examined awareness, perceived preparedness and resources, this section focuses on behavioural intentions in concrete crisis scenarios. By analysing open-ended responses, it becomes possible to examine how residents interpret risks, evaluate possible actions and reason about intended behaviour when faced with disruption, reflecting central processes in the Protective Action Decision Model (Lindell & Perry, 2012, p. 617 & 621). This allows for a more nuanced and in-depth understanding of preparedness as a practical and situational process rather than as a static condition. It is based on respondents' open-ended answers to two hypothetical crisis scenarios, one involving a warning signal and an escalating security situation and one involving a cyberattack causing power disruption and communication failure. In total, 94 responses were analysed for both scenarios. Responses varied in both length and level of detail, ranging from short and uncertain answers to more detailed descriptions of intended actions.

5.3.1 General patterns in intended actions

The scenario-based responses provide important insight into how respondents translate theoretical preparedness into imagined action. Overall, the responses suggest that individuals have some general awareness of what should be done in a crisis, but that this awareness is often not connected to concrete or pre-planned strategies. Instead of referring to specific preparations or routines, respondents frequently describe actions in vague or open-ended terms such as *"try to solve it as best as possible"*, *"do what feels right in the situation"* or *"figure it out somehow"*. Rather than referring to existing plans or resources, respondents tend to describe how they would react in the moment. Preparedness is largely understood as something managed during the crisis itself rather than planned in advance.

In several responses, this uncertainty becomes explicit. For example, some respondents state that *"I haven't really thought about it before"* or *"I don't know what I would do"*. Such statements show that preparedness is not integrated into everyday thinking or routines, but remains hypothetical until a crisis occurs. Even when respondents mention relevant actions, such as securing food, water or information, these are rarely described in terms of concrete steps, timelines or prior preparation. Levac et al. (2012, p. 730) show that individuals are often aware of preparedness measures without converting this awareness into concrete action. Kohn et al. (2012, p. 228) similarly highlight that lack of planning, time and practical preparedness often limits household preparedness. Lindell and Perry (2012) argue that individuals do not act on information directly, but first interpret and evaluate it before deciding how to respond (Lindell & Perry, 2012, p. 616-617). This suggests that respondents recognise possible actions, but struggle to translate this awareness into concrete action.

A closer examination of the responses also reveals some variation across demographic groups, although the overall pattern remains consistent. Differences between genders are relatively limited. However, female respondents more frequently express uncertainty or concern, using phrases such as "*It would be difficult*", which may indicate lower perceived confidence in their ability to act. Male respondents, in contrast, more often describe intended actions in slightly more confident terms, although these are still rarely linked to concrete planning or prior preparation. Some variation can also be observed across age groups. Younger respondents more often provide shorter and more uncertain answers, sometimes stating that they have not previously considered how they would act in a crisis. Older respondents on the other hand, more often mention specific actions such as securing resources or seeking information, although these responses are still generally not connected to structured plans or long-term preparation. This suggests that while awareness and understanding may increase with age, this does not necessarily translate into fully developed preparedness strategies.

The responses suggest a general pattern of situational reasoning, where individuals imagine responding to a crisis as it unfolds rather than relying on predefined strategies.

Kaneberg (2018, p. 5) shows that preparedness is often prioritised after crises occur rather than as part of proactive engagement. Lavelle (2012, p. 25-26) similarly argues that preparedness behaviour is often reactive rather than preventive. These findings contrast with the institutional framing identified in the document analysis, where preparedness is presented as something that should be planned and organised in advance. Preparedness is therefore institutionally constructed as a structured and proactive activity rather than something improvised in the moment. However, the scenario responses suggest that residents do not fully translate preparedness into practice in this way. Instead of referring to planned actions, they describe how they would attempt to manage the situation as it arises. A broader limitation in preparedness communication is that awareness does not consistently translate into preparedness behaviour.

Ning et al. (2021, p. 2-3) show that risk awareness alone is insufficient to produce preparedness behaviour without perceived ability and motivation. Amberson et al. (2024, p. 2 & 4) similarly argue that preparedness is shaped by behavioural support and practical conditions rather than information alone. The responses in this study support this perspective by indicating that residents may understand what is expected of them without feeling able or ready to act in a structured way. Preparedness therefore appears not as an integrated practice, but as a reactive and situational process, activated only when individuals are asked to imagine a crisis. Without prior planning, individuals may be forced to make decisions under stress and uncertainty, which can reduce the effectiveness of their response. Lindell and Perry (2012, p. 623) show that individuals often delay action until a threat becomes serious, which may further limit proactive preparedness behaviour. The absence of structured planning in the responses highlights that preparedness is not only about knowledge, but about the ability to organise that knowledge into actionable strategies. This reliance on improvisation suggests that preparedness is not part of everyday routines or practices, but remains situational and hypothetical.

5.3.2 Scenario 1: War-related warning scenario

The first scenario was presented to respondents as follows:

"You wake up to the warning signal Hesa Fredrik. At the same time, news reports state that the security situation in Sweden has worsened sharply and that there is a risk of military attacks. Mobile networks are still functioning, but they are overloaded. Information and mobility are limited. Describe as concretely and in as much detail as possible what actions you would take in this situation."

This scenario asked respondents to imagine a war-related warning situation in which information access and mobility were constrained. While some respondents focused on securing basic needs, others expressed clear difficulty imagining how they would act under such conditions. Statements such as "*I honestly don't know what I would do*" and "*It's hard to think about*" reflect the increased complexity associated with this type of scenario. This suggests that preparedness is more difficult to think through when the situation is perceived as extreme, uncertain or outside everyday experience. The responses also suggest that this scenario carries a stronger emotional weight, which may further limit individuals' ability to imagine and plan for action. One response clearly illustrates this uncertainty:

"*I honestly don't know what I would have done, it feels too big to be able to imagine*"

This response reflects the difficulty of translating abstract risk into concrete action. Slovic (2000, p. 233-234) shows that unfamiliar and uncontrollable risks are more difficult for individuals to interpret and respond to. The statement also suggests that preparedness is limited not only by resources, but by the ability to process extreme scenarios. At the same time, several responses show a strong reliance on authorities:

"*I would have followed the authorities' recommendations and waited for more information.*"

This reflects a shift in perceived responsibility from the individual to institutional actors. This shows that as situations are perceived as more severe or less controllable, responsibility is increasingly transferred from the individual to public authorities. Chen et al. (2019, p. 7-8) show that individuals often rely on authorities to manage crises, particularly in situations perceived as complex or beyond personal control. A comparison with the survey's scaled responses further reinforces this interpretation. Respondents reported relatively low levels of perceived ability to act in crisis situations 4.35 and preparedness for longer disruptions 4.11. These low levels of self-efficacy are reflected in the scenario responses, where many respondents express uncertainty or rely on improvised strategies rather than predefined plans. Ning et al. (2021, p. 2-3) show that preparedness behaviour is strongly influenced by perceived ability, meaning that individuals who lack confidence in their ability to act are less likely to translate awareness into action. These findings reinforce that low self-efficacy is not only expressed in the scenario responses, but also consistently reflected in the quantitative data. This interpretation is also supported by the scenario-specific rating question linked to this scenario, see figure 11.

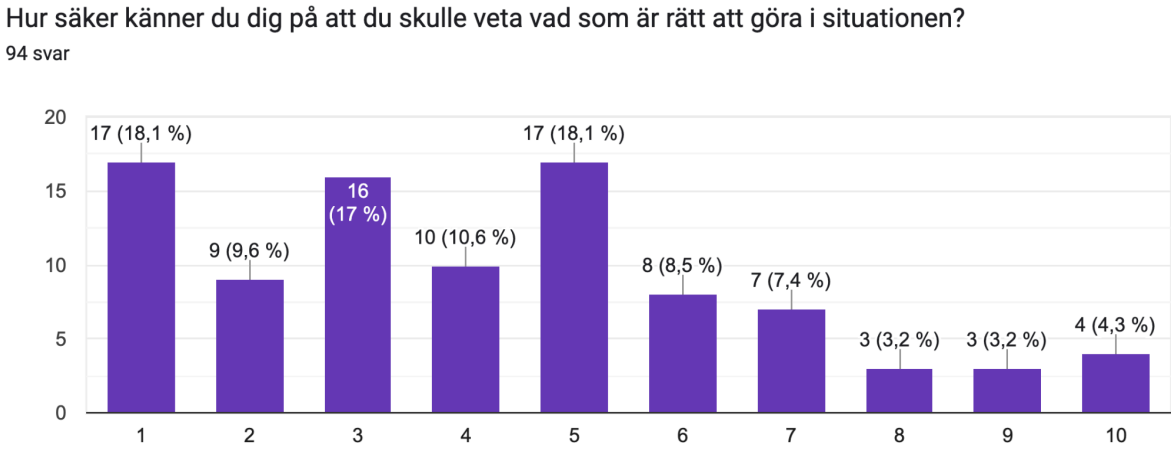


Figure 11. Respondents' confidence in knowing what actions to take in a war-related crisis scenario (94 responses).

As shown in Figure 11, when respondents were asked how confident they felt that they would know what the right action would be in this situation, 69 out of 94 respondents (73.4%) rated their confidence in the lower half of the scale (1-5). This indicates considerable uncertainty, even when respondents were asked to imagine what they would do. This suggests that even when individuals are presented with a clearly defined crisis scenario, their perceived ability to act remains limited. Some variation can be observed across demographic groups, although the overall pattern remains consistent. Younger respondents more often express uncertainty, while older respondents somewhat more frequently mention specific actions. However, across all groups, responses remain largely reactive rather than planned. One response illustrates how preparedness is partly framed as responsibility, but also as something difficult to fully anticipate:

"*Prepare the basement with extra blankets, water and light and gather my family. Then I would go to work because of my war placement. Preparing for a crisis/war is not easy, you are "caught off guard" no matter how much you try to prepare.*"

This response reflects an awareness of institutional expectations, such as preparing

supplies and fulfilling assigned roles. Coombs (2019) highlights that preparedness communication in the pre-crisis phase aims to clarify responsibilities and expected actions (Coombs, 2019, p. 10-11). At the same time, the statement that one is "*taken by surprise*" suggests that preparedness is not perceived as fully achievable in practice. Slovic (2000) shows that perceived control influences how individuals respond to risk, which may affect their engagement in preparedness (Slovic, 2000, p. 233-234). Another response highlights dependence on others and lack of personal preparedness:

"*I would have hoped for the best, I haven't prepared anything, I don't know where my nearest shelter is, I don't have any cash prepared. I would have hoped my partner would have known what we should do.*"

The response illustrates a clear gap between awareness and action. Levac et al. (2012, p. 730) show that individuals often have knowledge about preparedness without acting on it. The reliance on a partner also reflects how responsibility may be shifted within households rather than taken on individually. Chen et al. (2019, p. 5) demonstrate that reliance on others or authorities can reduce personal preparedness behaviour. A different type of response reflects more structured thinking, but still primarily reactive:

"*I would turn on the radio and listen for further instructions. Pack the most important things (documents such as a passport, warm clothes, essentials) and go to a safe place.*"

This response aligns more closely with institutional preparedness guidance, particularly in relation to information channels and evacuation. Lindell and Perry (2012) show that individuals tend to seek confirmation and guidance before acting in uncertain situations (Lindell & Perry, 2012, p. 622-623). However, the response still focuses on actions taken after the crisis has occurred rather than prior preparation. Kaneberg (2018, p. 5) highlights that preparedness is often activated only when a crisis unfolds rather than in advance. Similarly, another response demonstrates relatively high awareness of appropriate actions:

"*I would fill up bottles with water, as long as there is still pressure in the taps, which there should be for a while. Take freeze-dried food from the basement and canned food and gather everything in a bag with my valuables and stay indoors, so I have it all together. Keep the radio on and wait for further information.*"

The response demonstrates a more detailed understanding of resource management and crisis behaviour. At the same time, the actions described are initiated after the disruption has already occurred. Lavelle (2012) argues that preparedness behaviour is often reactive rather than preventive (Lavelle, 2012, p. 25-26). Taken together, these responses illustrate variation in how respondents interpret preparedness, but also reveal a consistent pattern. Even when respondents demonstrate awareness of appropriate actions, these are rarely described as part of pre-existing plans or routines. Instead, preparedness is activated in response to the crisis situation. Ning et al. (2021, p. 2-3) show that preparedness behaviour depends on perceived capability and motivation. The responses in this study shows that while awareness exists, it is not consistently translated into structured preparedness behaviour, reinforcing the gap between knowledge and action identified in previous research (Levac et al., 2012, p. 728 & 730). When comparing these responses to the institutional framing identified in the document analysis, a clear gap emerges. Municipal and national preparedness communication emphasises that individuals should be able to act independently and maintain basic needs for several days without external support. Preparedness is framed as a proactive and individual responsibility. However, the responses in this scenario suggest that as perceived severity increases, individuals shift responsibility towards institutional actors. This indicates that preparedness communication may not fully

capture how individuals perceive and respond to extreme and uncertain situations.

This gap reflects a broader limitation in preparedness communication. Eriksson (2024, p. 15) shows that one-way communication is often insufficient to influence behaviour. The responses in this study suggest that providing information about preparedness does not necessarily result in individuals feeling capable of acting in high-risk scenarios. Preparedness therefore appears to be constrained not only by access to resources, but also by perception, uncertainty and reliance on institutional actors. It is further limited by individuals' ability to anticipate and plan for unfamiliar and high-impact situations. The findings therefore indicate that increasing severity leads both to greater reliance on authorities and reduced ability to take concrete action. Overall, the responses to this scenario highlight how increasing severity and uncertainty influence preparedness. As situations become more complex and less controllable, individuals are more likely to experience uncertainty and rely on authorities or partners rather than acting independently. Slovic (2000) shows that perceived control influences how individuals respond to risk (Slovic, 2000, p. 233). This suggests that preparedness is not only shaped by knowledge, but by how individuals perceive their ability to act under extreme conditions. This further supports the patterns identified in the document analysis. Institutional communication largely assumes that preparedness follows information provision, but the findings instead show that perception, uncertainty and perceived ability play a central role in shaping behaviour.

5.3.3 Scenario 2: Power and Communication Failure

The second scenario was presented to respondents as follows:

"A large-scale cyberattack has caused a power outage in major parts of the municipality. You are at home when the electricity disappears. Internet and mobile networks are unavailable, payment systems do not work and transportation is limited. Describe as concretely and in as much detail as possible what you would do in this situation."

This scenario asked respondents to imagine a situation involving infrastructure failure and limited access to communication systems. Respondents mainly focused on securing basic needs such as food, water and light. Many responses reflect an immediate prioritisation of essential resources, with statements such as *"I would ration food and water and try to manage with what I have at home"* and *"use candles and ration resources"*. Some respondents provide more elaborate descriptions, for example: *"I would try to stay calm, use the resources I have at home, avoid opening the fridge too often and try to save both food and water as long as possible"*. These responses demonstrate that respondents are aware of fundamental survival needs and recognise the importance of self-sufficiency in situations where public services are unavailable.

Few respondents specify how long their resources would last or how they would manage if the disruption continued over several days. Even longer responses tend to remain general in nature, focusing on immediate response strategies rather than long-term planning. This interpretation is further supported by the survey results, where respondents reported low levels of preparedness for longer disruptions and limited access to key resources such as stored water and alternative communication tools. At the same time, many responses show uncertainty and hesitation. Expressions such as *"hope it doesn't last too long"* or *"I would probably just try to manage"* indicate that respondents may struggle to translate general preparedness ideas into concrete strategies. Some respondents explicitly express uncertainty, for example: *"I honestly don't know what I would do if it lasted several days"*. This uncertainty becomes more visible when respondents consider longer disruptions, suggesting that preparedness is often understood in terms of short-term response rather than long-term planning. This also reflects the low levels of self-efficacy identified in the survey. This pattern is further supported by the survey results presented below.



Figure 12. Respondents' confidence in knowing what actions to take in a power outage and communication disruption scenario (94 responses).

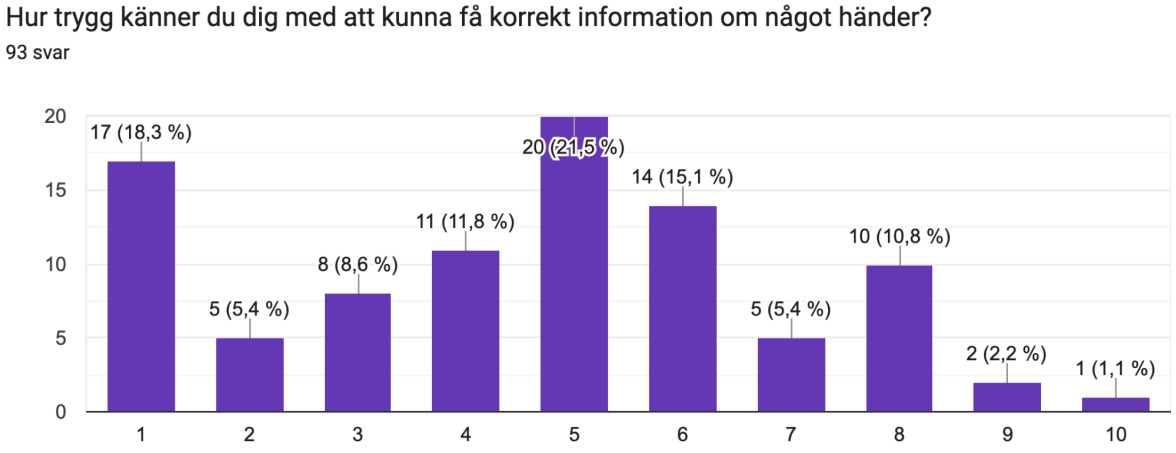


Figure 13. Respondents' perceived ability to access correct information during a power outage and communication disruption scenario (93 responses).

As shown in Figures 12 and 13, the scenario-specific survey results further support the high levels of uncertainty and low perceived ability to act identified in the responses. Specifically, 74 out of 94 respondents (78.7%) reported that they did not feel confident that they would know what the right action would be, compared to 20 respondents (21.3%) who reported that they did. In addition, responses regarding access to information show a similar pattern, with 75 out of 93 respondents (80.6%) rating their confidence in the lower to mid-range of the scale (1-6). These results reinforce the gap between awareness and the ability to act identified in the scenario responses.

Access to information emerges as a central concern in this scenario. Several respondents indicate that they would seek information through alternative channels, such as *"listen to the radio"* or *"talk to neighbours to understand what is happening"*. These responses suggest some awareness of non-digital communication systems. However, other respondents state that they would not know how to access information without digital tools, for example: *"I don't know how I would get information without my phone"* or *"everything I*

use is digital, so it would be very difficult". This pattern highlights a structural vulnerability linked to dependence on digital infrastructure, which limits individuals' ability to act independently when these systems fail. Kaneberg (2018, p. 22) shows that modern societies rely on multiple infrastructure systems that depend on each other, meaning that disruptions in one system can affect several others. The responses in this study illustrate how this dependence is reflected at the individual level, where loss of electricity and communication creates uncertainty and limits the ability to act independently. The variation in responses reflects differences in how individuals perceive and interpret risk. Although such responses were relatively uncommon, one response illustrates a higher level of practical awareness and more detailed reasoning:

"I save battery on my phone and use a flashlight or candles for lighting. Then I check the food and water at home, fill up containers with water and plan to eat food from the fridge and freezer first while opening them as little as possible. If necessary, I use cash since cards and Swish do not work. I stay at home, work with neighbours if needed and follow information on the radio until the situation changes."

The response demonstrates a more comprehensive understanding of crisis management, including resource prioritisation, infrastructure awareness and social collaboration. It also reflects institutional preparedness communication regarding alternative communication tools and payment preparedness (MSB, 2024, p. 16-17). At the same time, the actions described are still framed as responses initiated after the crisis has occurred, rather than as part of prior preparation. This reinforces previous findings that preparedness is often reactive rather than preventive (Lavelle, 2012, p. 25-26). Other responses highlight dependence on others and lack of access to critical resources:

"*I do not own a battery-powered radio, so without electricity I would not know what would be said, so I would start knocking on doors to see if a neighbour has one. Probably, if that did not work, I would take my belongings and go to friends or family after some time had passed.*"

This response illustrates both resource limitations and reliance on social networks. While the respondent demonstrates problem-solving ability, the lack of basic preparedness tools such as a radio limits independent action. This reflects research showing that preparedness is shaped not only by knowledge, but also by access to infrastructure, communication technologies and social support (Levac et al., 2012, p. 725 & 730). The reliance on neighbours and family also aligns with research on social capital, which highlights the importance of networks in crisis situations (Aldrich & Meyer, 2015, p. 256). Other responses express uncertainty in a more minimal and immediate form:

"*Here I am very unsure about what to do. But I would at least have the radio on to get information.*"

This response reflects a basic awareness of appropriate behaviour, but lacks further details or planning. Lindell and Perry (2012, p. 622) show that individuals often recognise possible actions but may not have translated them into concrete strategies, particularly in uncertain situations. Similarly, another response illustrates both lack of preparedness and reliance on hope:

"*Same here, as I don't have a radio or anything prepared, so getting information would not have been possible.. I would have just hoped for the best.*"

The statement highlights a clear absence of both preparation and perceived capability. The reliance on hope reflects what previous research identifies as low self-efficacy, where individuals do not feel able to influence the situation (Ning et al., 2021, p. 2-3). Taken

together, these responses illustrate significant variation in how preparedness is understood and put into practice. While some respondents demonstrate relatively advanced reasoning and awareness, others lack both resources and strategies. However, a common pattern across these responses is that preparedness is rarely described as something already in place, but rather as something that is put into practice once the crisis occurs.

When comparing these responses to the institutional framing identified in the document analysis, a clear mismatch emerges. While preparedness is presented as a proactive responsibility requiring planning, the scenario responses show that residents largely describe how they would manage with what they already have. This indicates that preparedness communication has not been fully translated into proactive behaviour, but instead is reflected in reactive responses rather than planned action. Taken together, the findings reflect broader limitations in preparedness communication. Lindell and Perry (2012, p. 617-618) argue that individuals must interpret and evaluate information before acting and unclear guidance may delay decision-making. The responses in this study support this perspective, as many respondents appear to understand general preparedness principles but lack the ability to translate them into concrete action. Preparedness therefore appears to be situational and improvised rather than structured and planned, particularly in scenarios involving longer disruptions and infrastructure failure.

5.3.5 Infrastructure Dependence

The responses clearly demonstrate a strong dependence on infrastructure systems, particularly electricity and digital communication. When these systems are disrupted in the scenarios, respondents frequently express uncertainty or concern. Statements such as *"everything depends on my phone"* and *"without electricity it would be very difficult"* illustrate how central these systems are to everyday life. This dependence becomes particularly visible when respondents struggle to imagine alternative ways of accessing information or communicating with others. While some respondents mention alternatives such as radio, these responses are less common, suggesting that alternative communication strategies may not be fully integrated into everyday preparedness practices. This also reflects a broader shift in modern societies, where everyday practices such as payment, communication and access to information are increasingly dependent on digital systems, making individuals more vulnerable when these systems fail (MSB, 2024, p. 17 & 23). This pattern is also reflected in the survey results, where only a small proportion of respondents reported having access to alternative communication tools such as battery-powered radios 21.3%. This suggests that reliance on digital infrastructure is reflected in limited access to alternative systems within households.

Some variation can be observed across demographic groups. Younger respondents more frequently expressed dependence on digital communication and uncertainty regarding alternative information channels, which aligns with the survey results where younger age groups reported higher reliance on social media as a primary information source. Older respondents more often referred to traditional media such as radio and television, reflecting differences in everyday information practices. However, across all groups reliance on digital infrastructure remained a dominant pattern. While these systems enable everyday functioning, they also create vulnerabilities when disrupted. The responses therefore highlight a tension between technological dependence and preparedness, where individuals rely on systems that may not be available in crisis situations. This supports the argument that preparedness is shaped not only by individual behaviour, but also by structural conditions (Kaneberg, 2018, p. 22). This stands in contrast to the institutional framing identified in the document analysis, where residents are expected to rely on alternative information channels such as radio and official warning systems.

This strong dependence on infrastructure systems reflects broader structural conditions in modern societies, where everyday life relies heavily on technical systems.

Research shows that such dependencies create systemic vulnerabilities, as disruptions in one system can rapidly affect multiple aspects of society (Kaneberg, 2018, p. 17-18). The responses illustrate that preparedness is not only an individual issue, but also shaped by structural conditions that limit individuals' ability to act independently. When critical systems such as electricity and communication are disrupted, individuals may lack both the resources and the knowledge required to respond effectively.

5.3.6 Social Support and Preparedness

While most responses focus on individual actions, some highlight the importance of social networks and collective support. Statements such as *"check on neighbours and help each other"* and *"stay with family and support each other"* indicate that some respondents view preparedness as a shared responsibility. These responses suggest that social relationships may function as an important resource in crisis situations, particularly when formal systems are disrupted. Informal networks can provide support, information and coordination, which may enhance resilience at the local level. However, the social dimension is not consistently mentioned across responses. Many respondents focus primarily on individual or household-level actions, suggesting that preparedness is often understood as a personal responsibility rather than a collective process. This also aligns with the survey results presented in section 5.2, where preparedness is primarily understood in terms of individual responsibility, with limited emphasis on collective or community-based preparedness. This pattern is visible in the scenario responses, where many respondents refer to contacting or gathering family members, while fewer mention neighbours or broader forms of collective action.

This stands in some contrast to the institutional framing identified in the document analysis where working together, neighbourhood support and shared responsibility are emphasised as key parts of preparedness. The fact that these perspectives are mentioned less often suggests that they are not fully part of how individuals think about preparedness. This uneven focus on social preparedness aligns with research showing that although social networks are important for resilience, they are not always actively considered in preparedness behaviour (Aldrich & Meyer, 2015, p. 256 & 263). The findings suggest that while social support exists as a potential resource, it is not fully integrated into how individuals think about preparedness. Instead, respondents tend to rely on neighbours mainly to obtain information or support when systems fail, rather than as part of a pre-existing plan. This indicates that social networks function more as backup in situations of uncertainty than as an integrated part of preparedness practices.

5.3.7 Gap between knowledge and action

Respondents generally demonstrate awareness of preparedness principles, but struggle to translate this awareness into concrete and confident behaviour. This is reflected in responses such as *"I know you should have supplies, but I don't really have anything prepared"* and *"I would try to do the right thing, but I'm not sure what that is"*. These statements illustrate that preparedness is not limited by lack of information, but by the ability to act on that information. Statements such as *"I know I should have a radio, but I don't have one"* illustrate that the problem might not be the lack of information, but the assumption that providing information is sufficient for generating preparedness behaviour. Individuals may understand what is recommended, but still face barriers related to motivation, confidence or perceived capability.

Research shows that preparedness behaviour is influenced by factors such as self-efficacy and perceived ability to act, rather than knowledge alone (Ning et al., 2021, p. 2). This pattern is further supported by the scenario-specific survey questions. In the power outage scenario, 74 out of 94 respondents reported that they did not feel confident that they would know what the right action would be. This indicates that low perceived capability is not only expressed qualitatively in the responses, but also reflected in the quantitative data.

Similarly, in the warning scenario, responses were concentrated in the lower half of the scale, indicating uncertainty even when respondents were asked to describe their actions.

In addition, risk perception plays a role in shaping behaviour. If risks are perceived as unlikely or distant, individuals may not prioritise preparedness even when they are aware of it (Slovic, 2000, p. 394). The responses therefore reflect a broader challenge in preparedness research, where increasing awareness does not result in behavioural change. This gap between knowledge and action can be understood as a central limitation in preparedness communication. As a result, preparedness remains at the level of intention rather than being put into practice. This supports research showing that preparedness behaviour is more strongly influenced by perceived capability and motivation than by knowledge alone (Ning et al., 2021, p. 2-3).

5.3.8 Summary

Overall, the scenario-based responses reveal that residents rarely describe preparedness as something already planned or integrated into everyday life. Instead, preparedness is primarily expressed as reactive and situational, where individuals attempt to manage crises as they unfold rather than relying on pre-existing plans or routines. Across both scenarios, many respondents demonstrate general awareness of appropriate actions, such as securing information, managing basic resources and contacting family members. However, this awareness is rarely connected to structured preparedness strategies or long-term planning. The findings also show that preparedness varies depending on the type of crisis scenario. In the war-related scenario, respondents more frequently express uncertainty and reliance on authorities, while the infrastructure disruption scenario generates more practically oriented but still largely improvised responses. The findings therefore suggest that preparedness is shaped not only by access to information, but also by perceived capability, uncertainty, infrastructure dependence and everyday conditions. This reveals tensions between institutional expectations of proactive preparedness and how residents imagine responding to crises in practice. Preparedness therefore appears less as part of everyday practice and more as a reactive and situational response.

5.4 Institutional Perspectives

This section presents findings from interviews with two municipal actors involved in crisis preparedness and communication. The interviews provide insight into how preparedness is understood, organised and communicated at the institutional level, complementing the document analysis and survey results by providing an internal perspective on governance, communication practices and perceived challenges. The empirical material is based on interviews with a preparedness officer and a crisis communication officer. In the Swedish municipal context, these roles correspond to tjänsteman i beredskap (TiB), responsible for preparedness coordination and response and kommunikatör i beredskap (KiB), responsible for crisis communication. To ensure anonymity, the respondents are referred to as “TiB” and “KiB” throughout the analysis. The findings highlight how preparedness is shaped by organisational structures, resource constraints and institutional expectations of individual responsibility. The interviews also provide insight into how institutional actors themselves understand the gap between awareness and action identified in the survey results. In this sense, the interviews not only reinforce patterns identified in previous sections, but also help explain why these patterns occur, particularly in relation to communication practices, behavioural factors and perceived responsibility.

5.4.1 Organisation and Coordination

The interview confirms the hierarchical and structured organisation of crisis preparedness identified in the document analysis. Preparedness work is described as both strategic and operational, involving coordination between multiple actors and levels of governance. The respondent explains that their role involves both long-term planning and immediate response:

"*I work as a preparedness strategist, focusing on strategic preparedness issues and I also serve as a duty officer in preparedness.*" - TiB

Crisis management is described as a network-based process, in which different actors are activated depending on the nature and scale of the situation. Rather than being managed through a single structure, responsibility is distributed across multiple organisational units and external actors, requiring continuous coordination and information-sharing. These external actors include for example the police, SOS Alarm and the County Administrative Board (länsstyrelsen) depending on the type of incident. Within this structure, the function of TiB is central, acting as a coordinating center that connects actors, enables communication and ensures that relevant functions are activated and informed at an early stage. As described by the TiB:

"*It is the municipality's emergency receiver… you could say it functions as a spider in the web.*" - TiB

The TiB role does not necessarily solve the situation directly but instead ensures that the appropriate municipal departments and external actors are informed and able to act. In this sense, crisis management emerges as a dynamic and situational network, where the TiB activates and connects relevant actors depending on the specific characteristics of the event. This confirms the broader pattern identified in the document analysis, where preparedness is organised through formal structures, clearly defined roles and hierarchical coordination systems. The municipality operates through formal roles, escalation procedures and collaboration with external actors. At the same time, the respondent emphasises that crisis situations are highly dynamic:

"*It is difficult to say "this is how it is" or "this is how we do things"… it will likely change next week, for example when new directives are introduced or when authorities assign new tasks that we need to respond to.*" - TiB

The interview suggests that preparedness governance is not static, but continuously shaped by changing conditions, policies and directives from higher levels of authority. It also reflects the complexity of crisis management, where flexibility and adaptability are required alongside formal structures. In addition to this, the KiB interview shows that crisis communication is organised as an ongoing function within the municipality.

"*We have a function called communicator in preparedness… where we rotate on-call schedules so that there is always a standby function 24 hours a day… where managers within the organisation can reach us if communication support is needed in relation to crisis or safety-related issues.*" - KiB

This highlights that crisis communication is not only reactive, but also organised as an ongoing function that is closely connected to the broader coordination system described above. The KiB interview also shows that crisis communication is embedded in the municipality's broader communication structure, rather than functioning as a completely separate preparedness unit. The respondent describes how the communication department is responsible for several of the municipality's main channels, including social media, the website and internal communication and that crisis communication is therefore integrated into everyday communication work. This suggests that preparedness communication is shaped by the same institutional structures, priorities and channel logics as municipal communication more broadly.

5.4.2 Expectations of Individual Responsibility

A central theme in the interviews is the strong emphasis on individual responsibility, which closely aligns with the institutional framing identified in the document analysis. In particular, responsibility is framed not only as an expectation, but as a necessary condition for the functioning of the municipal response system. The respondent repeatedly highlights that residents are expected to manage independently during the initial phase of a crisis, particularly in relation to access to basic resources such as water, food and heating:

"*People have been talking about seven days, but in the new recommendations it says fourteen days... but I think that if you have seven days, if everyone had seven days, that would be fantastic... it is also about not exhausting the municipality's resources... then you really need to have your own water... and if the water is not enough, then you also need to escalate that in order to access water resources from elsewhere.*" - TiB

This quote shows that individual preparedness is not only important for individuals, but also necessary for the functioning of the wider system. Preparedness is framed not simply as a recommendation, but as a condition for maintaining system capacity and ensuring that limited municipal resources can be prioritised. This reflects the same logic identified in the document analysis, where individual preparedness is presented as a way to reduce pressure on public resources.

"*It will be calmer if people have their own preparedness. Everything will be much calmer for those who are responsible for managing the situation, for example distributing water or providing information, because then we know that people are prepared at home. We will be able to work in a calm and structured way and we may not even need to supply water tanks during the first days if people have their own water. Otherwise, there will likely be long queues...*" - TiB

The respondent further emphasises that preparedness at the household level directly affects the municipality's ability to respond effectively. In particular, individual preparedness is described as a factor that enables a more controlled and structured response, while a lack of preparedness risks creating pressure on municipal resources and leading to reactive crisis management, such as long queues and increased demand for emergency support. This is also reflected in the KiB interview, where the respondent suggests that many residents still expect that help will come from others, rather than seeing preparedness as their own immediate responsibility. The KiB respondent emphasises that people may assume that someone else will take care of the situation, even though individuals are expected to manage for the first few days before the wider system is fully activated. This reinforces tensions between institutional expectations of individual responsibility and how that responsibility is understood in practice.

"*I think people often expect that the responsibility lies with someone else... that people think that if something happens, I will get help... But they may not ask themselves, okay, but from whom? ... I actually have a responsibility for myself and those closest to me... I have to manage for a few days before the system kicks in.*" - KiB

At the same time, the TiB interview reinforces this pattern by highlighting a similar tendency to shift responsibility towards authorities:

"*People tend to think that someone else will come, that the municipality will take care of it... people think that someone else will take over the responsibility... but it actually lies with ourselves.*" - TiB

This reflects the variation in how individuals perceive responsibility, as shown in the survey results. This pattern is also reflected in previous research, which shows that

individuals in welfare states often expect institutional support during crises, even when policies emphasise self-reliance (Aldrich & Meyer, 2015, p. 256). This highlights a gap between institutional expectations of individual responsibility and how people perceive their role, which is often shaped by trust in the welfare system. This variation is also visible in the survey results, where responsibility is interpreted differently among residents, with some emphasising individual responsibility while others expect support from authorities. The interview therefore helps explain why institutional expectations of individual responsibility are not always reflected in how residents perceive their own role in crisis preparedness. This mirrors the findings in the survey (section 5.2.7), where responsibility is interpreted in different ways and often partly shifted towards authorities. The interviews therefore highlight a mismatch between what institutions expect and how the public perceives their role. The KiB respondent further emphasises that crisis systems require individuals to manage independently during the initial phase:

"*No one is going to come flying in… you have to manage on your own for a few days before the system kicks in… because there is an escalation chain and a prioritisation of how things need to be handled.*" - KiB

At the same time, the KiB interview further emphasises that public engagement with preparedness may have changed in recent years. The respondent reflects that residents today are likely more open to preparedness communication because the security situation is perceived as less stable and more personally relevant than before. This indicates that risk perception may increase openness to preparedness messages, even if it does not automatically result in concrete preparedness behaviour.

5.4.3 Gap Between Information and Action

The findings highlight a clear gap between awareness and action, as identified in the survey results. While residents report high levels of exposure to preparedness information, this does not translate into actual preparedness or confidence. The interviews provide important insight into why this gap occurs, suggesting that the issue is not a lack of information but rather how information is perceived, prioritised and acted upon. Together, this highlights that awareness does not necessarily translate into action in practice. One key explanation identified in the interviews is emotional and psychological resistance. As the TiB respondent explains:

"*I think some people find it difficult, it feels uncomfortable to receive this information about crises and war… it becomes real in a way… some may think it is not something to focus on.*" - TiB

This suggests that preparedness information may cause discomfort or avoidance, particularly when risks are perceived as more real and personally relevant. Rather than motivating action, increased awareness may instead lead to disengagement. This aligns with previous research showing that emotional responses such as avoidance can reduce engagement with preparedness information, especially when risks are perceived as overwhelming or difficult to relate to in everyday life (Chen et al., 2019, p. 5). Another factor highlighted in the interviews is information overload. The respondent describes how preparedness messages compete with a constant flow of information:

"*There's just so much information being pumped out… social media and everything else, I think we're quite overloaded with information… and then you get a brochure as well… am I supposed to read this too?*" - TiB

In this context, preparedness information risks being deprioritised or ignored. This supports findings in crisis communication research showing that information alone is often insufficient to change behaviour and that communication needs to be clear, timely and easy

to act upon (MSB, 2022, p. 14 & 16). In relation to the findings of this study, this helps explain why widespread exposure to preparedness information does not necessarily lead to action. This further supports the idea that behaviour is shaped not only by access to information, but by how that information is interpreted, prioritised and integrated into everyday decision-making. The interviews also highlight how preparedness is often postponed despite awareness of its importance. As the TiB respondent notes:

"*Some say, "no, I need to deal with that"... I think it's very mixed, some say they can manage for two days and two days is better than zero... but try to get up to seven days.*" - TiB

This reflects a gap between intention and behaviour, where individuals recognise the importance of preparedness but delay taking concrete steps. This pattern is clearly visible in the survey results, where residents report awareness of preparedness recommendations but low levels of actual preparedness and confidence. It is further reinforced in the scenario responses, where intended actions are often uncertain, reactive and lack clear structure. The KiB interview provides particularly strong confirmation of this gap, as the respondent explicitly reflects on their own lack of preparedness despite being aware of the issue:

"*I have no crisis preparedness... I haven't done the work... For me, it's probably a lot about naivety. You kind of dodge it, you think it won't happen. If it really starts burning, then you prepare at that point... I think that's a human tendency. It's hard to encourage people to prepare for a crisis that they don't really know. Sweden is a country where there has been over 200 years of peace...*" - KiB

This illustrates that the gap between awareness and action is not only observed among residents, but also recognised at the institutional level as a broader behavioural pattern. More specifically, the respondent highlights how this gap is shaped by avoidance, reactive behaviour and low perceived risk. Preparedness is postponed because individuals tend to "dodge" the issue and only act once a crisis becomes real, while long-term peace contributes to a perception of crises as distant or unlikely. The respondent further highlights how preparedness may be actively deprioritised or avoided:

"*That so many say they have taken part of the information, but when they get it home they throw it away... that reflects that there may not really be an interest and that people might be a bit naive.*" - KiB

This further illustrates how awareness does not necessarily translate into engagement, as information may be actively dismissed despite being available. It also highlights the role of a lack of interest and naivety in shaping preparedness behaviour. This is particularly relevant given that the brochure explicitly encourages residents to keep the material for future use, thereby highlighting a clear gap between intended use and actual behaviour (Norrköpings kommun, n.d.-b, p. 1 & 24). In addition, the KiB respondent emphasises that individuals may struggle to act on risks they have not personally experienced:

"*It's difficult to encourage people to prepare for a crisis that they don't really know... when you haven't experienced a war... I haven't experienced a war... then it's probably harder to take action, you're fully aware that you should do more, but you don't.*" - KiB

This highlights the role of risk perception in shaping behaviour. When crises are perceived as distant, unlikely or unfamiliar, preparedness is more easily postponed. This is consistent with research showing that preparedness is often deprioritised in developed countries where risks are perceived as unlikely or abstract (Kaneberg, 2018, p. 21). At the

same time, the findings suggest that this pattern reflects a broader structural challenge. Previous research shows that preparedness systems are often characterised by a lack of coordination and integration which can make it difficult to translate information into practical action (Kaneberg, 2018, p. 22). While this is often discussed at the institutional level, the results of this study suggest that similar challenges also exist at the individual level, where information is available but not effectively used or acted upon. In other words, information is widely available but not effectively integrated into everyday practices.

Together, these findings demonstrate that the gap between awareness and action cannot be explained by lack of information alone. Instead, it reflects a combination of emotional responses, information overload and risk perception, which shape how preparedness information is interpreted and acted upon. This reinforces insights from both crisis communication theory and risk perception theory, which emphasise that behaviour is shaped not only by access to information, but by how that information is understood and experienced in practice.

5.4.4 Variation in preparedness and practical constraints

The findings highlight that preparedness is unevenly distributed across the population, reflecting patterns identified in the survey results, where residents reported varying levels of access to basic resources rather than consistent preparedness. This variation is not only descriptive but provides important insight into how preparedness is shaped by both individual and structural factors. The TiB respondent describes preparedness levels as highly uneven, with some individuals being well prepared while others lack any form of preparedness. This uneven distribution reinforces the survey findings, where preparedness is often incomplete rather than comprehensive and where some residents report access to food, water or alternative resources, while others report no preparation at all. The interviews suggest that preparedness is shaped not only by individual choice but also by broader structural and contextual conditions that influence individuals' ability to prepare.
Similar patterns are reflected in the survey results, where many respondents reported access to some basic resources, but not fully developed or structured preparedness strategies.

Previous research supports this interpretation, showing that preparedness in modern societies is not only dependent on knowledge, but also on access to resources, infrastructure and everyday living conditions (Kaneberg, 2018, p. 20). In addition, the increasing complexity of modern societies including reliance on supply systems, creates conditions where preparedness becomes more difficult to implement at the individual level (Kaneberg, 2018, p. 24). The interviews provide concrete examples of how these structural constraints affect preparedness in practice. In particular, the TiB respondent highlights how limited space and material resources can restrict preparedness:

"*Then it's also about space… it's difficult to have maybe four 20-25 litre containers in the basement. And then you're supposed to replace the water every six months.*" - TiB

The interview findings illustrate how preparedness is not only a matter of awareness or motivation, but also of opportunity, as described in the COM-B model (MSB, 2022, p. 14 & 17). Even when individuals recognise the importance of preparedness, practical constraints such as limited storage space, physical capacity and resource availability may prevent them from acting (Tierney, 2014, p. 227 & 233). This helps explain why the survey results show relatively high awareness of preparedness recommendations alongside lower levels of actual preparedness. The interviews also highlight how preparedness varies between different living contexts, particularly between urban and rural environments:

"*People living in rural areas are probably more prepared than those living in urban areas.*" - TiB

The rural-urban difference reflects how preparedness is shaped by lived experience and everyday practices. In rural contexts, individuals may be more used to managing disruptions such as power outages or supply limitations, which increases both capability and confidence. In contrast, urban residents are often more dependent on infrastructure systems and external services, which may reduce both perceived need and practical preparedness. This aligns with risk perception theory, where familiarity and perceived control influence behaviour (Slovic, 2000, p. 232-233). This helps explain variations observed in the survey results, where preparedness appears uneven and often limited in scale. It also aligns with the scenario responses where preparedness often appeared reactive and improvised rather than based on prior planning. The variation in preparedness is also linked to differences in how individuals access and engage with information. As highlighted in the KiB interview, some groups may be more difficult to reach through existing communication channels:

"*There are always target groups that are harder to reach… for example older individuals who may not use social media, they can be more vulnerable.*" - KiB

The findings suggest that preparedness is not only shaped by resources and living conditions, but also by differences in communication access and how information is received. The survey results also showed that respondents aged 55 and above relied less on social media and more on traditional media channels such as television compared to younger respondents. This indicates that preparedness communication may reach different groups unevenly depending on the communication channel used. As a result, certain groups may face additional barriers to preparedness, reinforcing existing inequalities. Variation in preparedness is further illustrated in a reflection from the TiB respondent:

"*It's probably very mixed… some are very well prepared and have food, water and other supplies, while others have nothing at all.*" - TiB

The statement shows that preparedness varies across the population, from highly prepared individuals to those with little or no preparation. It also reflects a pattern identified in the survey results where preparedness is often limited to short-term rather than long-term planning. These differences suggest that preparedness is often incomplete and develops gradually rather than being fully established. Taken together, these findings reinforce the broader finding that preparedness is frequently reactive and incomplete. The KiB interview further emphasises that preparedness is shaped not only by resources and context, but also by experience and perceived relevance:

"*I think that the times we live in and people's experiences connected to these issues play a very big role…*" - KiB

The quote highlights the role of risk perception in shaping preparedness behaviour. When risks are perceived as unfamiliar or not personally experienced, they are less likely to be translated into concrete action (Slovic, 2000, p. 233). This helps explain why preparedness may be deprioritised even when individuals are aware of potential risks, as also observed in the survey findings. The findings therefore suggest that preparedness is shaped not only by awareness and communication, but also by structural conditions, lived experience and perceived relevance. This challenges institutional assumptions that providing information is sufficient to generate preparedness, as individuals' ability to act is also influenced by access to resources, everyday conditions and prior experience.

5.4.5 Communication challenges and limitations

Communication is described as a central challenge in the interviews. While the municipality provides information through multiple channels, the respondents acknowledge that this is not sufficient. This limitation is also clearly expressed in the KiB interview, where the respondent questions the assumption that information automatically reaches residents:

"*It is a bit naive to think that all municipal residents will turn to the municipality's channels… we can publish things, but whether they are actually received, I'm not entirely sure… it depends on people also seeking the information themselves.*" - KiB

These communication challenges can be further understood through research on civil preparedness systems, which shows that the provision of information alone does not necessarily lead to engagement or preparedness (Eriksson, 2024, p. 15). Studies show that preparedness communication often relies on distribution rather than interaction, which limits its effectiveness in influencing behaviour (Kaneberg, 2018, p. 24). This aligns closely with the interview findings, where communication is described as available but not necessarily received or acted upon. In addition, research on Swedish civil preparedness emphasises that coordination between actors is often complex, particularly in systems involving multiple stakeholders (Heidenfors Armblad, 2023, p. 23). While this is typically discussed in relation to institutional actors, the findings in this study suggest that a similar lack of integration occurs in how residents engage with preparedness information, as also shown in the survey results.

Furthermore, previous research highlights that actors often engage more actively only when a crisis has already occurred (Heidenfors Armblad, 2023, p. 8). This reactive pattern is also visible at the individual level in this study, where both survey and scenario responses show that preparedness is often delayed and activated only when a crisis becomes urgent. This suggests that preparedness communication may struggle not only with reach, but also with timing and perceived relevance. The TiB respondent reinforces this by emphasising that information exists, but does not necessarily reach or engage residents:

"*We actually have quite a lot on crisis preparedness, but we need to communicate it better, both more broadly and more specifically… some people take the information and just throw it away… it's difficult to reach everyone… but we need to reach more people and talk about it and discuss it.*" - TiB

These findings highlight that the challenge is not only whether information is available, but how it is received and prioritised by individuals. The fact that some residents actively dismiss the information suggests that disengagement may be linked to low perceived relevance or divided attention in everyday contexts. The limitations of one-way communication are also evident. This reflects a broader limitation in public risk communication, where the effectiveness of communication depends not only on the provision of information, but on whether messages are perceived as relevant and worth engaging with. The brochure is described as useful, but insufficient on its own:

"*The brochure is all well and good… but when people don't even look at it, then you need to keep pushing the message in different ways.*" - TiB

The quote highlights that preparedness communication is largely information-driven, but lacks mechanisms that support engagement and behavioural change. As further emphasised in the KiB interview, communication effectiveness depends not only on the availability of information, but also on whether individuals actively engage with it:

"*We have information… but people also have to receive it or actively seek for it themselves.*" - KiB

Website statistics provided by the KiB respondent from Norrköping municipality covering the period 7 April 2025 to 7 April 2026 further illustrate that preparedness-related engagement is uneven rather than absent. Across the preparedness-related pages included in the material, the municipality's website recorded 3,154 visits, 5,261 page views and 2,331

page-level unique visitors during the observed period. Considering that Norrköping municipality has approximately 145,000 inhabitants (Norrköpings kommun, 2026a), these figures suggest that preparedness-related information reaches only a relatively limited proportion of residents. The most visited pages were Krisberedskap (Crisis preparedness) with 608 visits, Civil beredskap (Civil preparedness) with 580 visits and Detta behöver du ha i din krisväska (What you need in your emergency kit) with 564 visits. By contrast, Beredskapsveckan i Norrköping 2025 (Emergency Preparedness Week in Norrköping 2025) attracted only 20 visits.

The statistics suggest that residents are more likely to engage with preparedness information when it is framed in concrete and immediately practical terms such as crisis kits, crisis plans and practical guidance, rather than as general institutional or campaign-based information. The statistics therefore do not indicate a complete lack of interest in preparedness, but rather a selective and relatively limited pattern of engagement. This also suggests that preparedness may be perceived as less urgent or less personally relevant compared to other safety-related issues. This interpretation aligns with the survey findings, where respondents describe encountering preparedness information mainly through indirect channels such as social media and news. The scenario responses further reinforce this pattern, as many participants report waiting for instructions or relying on external sources during crises rather than using previously gained preparedness knowledge from official municipal communication channels. Taken together, these findings suggest that the issue is not simply a lack of information, but a mismatch between institutional communication and what residents perceive as relevant and useful in everyday contexts. Preparedness information is available and accessible, but not consistently prioritised or integrated into everyday practices. The respondent also emphasises the need for repeated and multi-channel communication, including social media and workplace discussions:

"*We need to talk more about it and bring it onto the agenda… in workplaces, staff meetings and other meetings, so that it is actually discussed… that people ask, do you have emergency preparedness at home?*" - TiB

The interviews support the findings from both the document analysis and survey, where communication is largely information-driven but lacks engagement and behavioural support. The KiB interview also provides a more concrete picture of how local crisis information is communicated in practice. Depending on the situation, the municipality may use its website, social media, press releases, SMS messaging and coordinated messages together with external actors such as police or rescue services. In this sense, local crisis communication is not described as relying on one fixed channel, but as situational and adapted to the scale and character of the event. The KiB interview further suggests that channel choice is not standardised, but depends on who needs to be reached, what kind of event has occurred and how broad the impact is. Communication is therefore not described as uniform, which adds an important aspect to the analysis. At the same time, the KiB and TiB interview highlights recurring proactive initiatives aimed at increasing public awareness and preparedness, such as the initiative Beredskapsveckan (Emergency preparedness week):

"*During week 39, we organise Beredskapsveckan… the purpose is to inspire and spread knowledge about preparedness to private individuals, as well as to create awareness of total defence.*" - KiB

"*Beredskapsveckan is very important… we need more initiatives like that such as preparedness weeks and preparedness days… we participate every year with lectures, discussions and different activities to increase awareness and preparedness.*" - TiB

During this week, multiple communication efforts are used, including digital platforms, public displays and social media, in order to reach a broader audience. This

demonstrates that the municipality works strategically with awareness-building over time, rather than relying solely on one-time information efforts such as brochures. However, this institutional emphasis on Emergency preparedness week is not fully reflected in patterns of public engagement. As indicated by the website statistics presented earlier, campaign-specific content such as Beredskapsveckan attracts limited attention compared to more concrete and practical preparedness information. This suggests that, although the initiative is prioritised and widely promoted at the institutional level, it may not be perceived as equally relevant or engaging by residents.

From an analytical perspective, this highlights a mismatch between how preparedness communication is designed and how it is received in practice. While Emergency preparedness week represents a concentrated and proactive communication effort, its impact appears to be constrained by the same factors identified in the study including selective engagement, perceived relevance and information overload in everyday contexts. This reinforces the broader finding that visibility does not necessarily translate into engagement and that awareness-raising initiatives may have limited effect if they are not aligned with how individuals prioritise and interact with information. However, resource constraints are another highlighted subject as a limiting factor:

"*There are only three of us… if we were ten, it would be a completely different situation.*" - TiB

This indicates that the effectiveness of preparedness communication is not only a matter of strategy, but also of organisational capacity. Another limitation that becomes visible through the KiB interview is the lack of clear follow-up and evaluation of communication efforts. While information campaigns and communication initiatives are described, it remains less clear how their effects are evaluated in practice. This suggests that preparedness communication may place greater emphasis on producing and distributing information than on systematic evaluation and organisational learning. This perspective is significant since effective crisis communication depends not only on reaching people, but also on understanding whether the communication actually influences behaviour.

5.4.6 Trust and Preparedness Behaviour

The interview also highlights the importance of trust in shaping behaviour. This is further reinforced in the KiB interview, where trust is described as central to communication:

"*Information should be credible… we want to create a sense of safety and credibility… it should be some form of quality marking to reduce the risk of rumours or disinformation.*" - KiB

The respondent notes that trust in authorities influences whether people follow recommendations:

"*It is important that they have trust… otherwise it will become a bit chaotic.*" - TiB

This aligns with the theoretical framework and document analysis, where trust is identified as a key factor in risk communication. This reflects Slovic's (2000) argument that trust plays a central role in how risk information is interpreted and whether institutions are seen as credible and legitimate sources of guidance. At the same time, Slovic (2000) also shows that responses to risk are shaped by factors such as perceived control, familiarity and emotional reactions, which suggests that trust alone cannot fully explain preparedness behaviour (Slovic, 2000, p. 392 & 396). This is also reflected in the survey results, where trust in authorities is mid-level rather than high, suggesting that while trust exists it may not be strong enough on its own to motivate preparedness behaviour. However, the interviews suggest that even when trust in authorities exists, individuals may still lack the motivation,

resources or capacity to act. This suggests that trust functions as a necessary but not sufficient condition for preparedness behaviour.

The TiB interview also raised the issue of shelters and protected spaces, which adds an important practical dimension to the findings. Although many residents in the survey reported uncertainty regarding shelter locations, the interview indicates that this is part of a broader preparedness challenge. Physical protection is not only about knowing where a traditional shelter is located, but also about how residents understand protective measures more broadly and what kinds of spaces or arrangements may be relevant in different crisis situations. This highlights that preparedness challenges are not only related to trust or awareness, but also to more concrete and context-specific knowledge, such as where to seek protection and how to act in specific situations. This suggests that preparedness communication may need to address not only warning systems and general preparedness advice, but also more concrete questions about protection, sheltering and local conditions. Taken together, these findings reinforce the broader argument of this study, that preparedness behaviour cannot be explained by information or trust alone, but is shaped by a combination of communication practices, individual perceptions and structural conditions that influence how preparedness is understood and acted upon in everyday contexts.

5.4.7 Summary

Overall, the interview findings reinforce and deepen the patterns identified in both the document analysis and survey results and scenario-based responses. Preparedness is institutionally framed as a shared responsibility, but with a strong emphasis on individual self-reliance. The municipality operates through structured coordination and formal governance systems, while also adapting to changing conditions and external demands. The KiB interview further strengthens these findings by highlighting that the gap between awareness and action is not only a public issue, but reflects a broader behavioural pattern shaped by experience, perception and everyday priorities. The interviews also point towards future development needs. In particular, the KiB perspective suggests that crisis communication needs to remain adaptive, coordinated and focused on how residents receive and engage with information. This indicates that effective preparedness communication is not static, but must continuously develop in relation to changing societal conditions, media habits and public expectations.

At the same time, the interviews highlight several key limitations. Institutional actors recognise that awareness does not automatically lead to action and that communication alone is insufficient to generate preparedness. This reflects broader crisis communication research, which emphasises that communication is not only about providing information, but also about helping people understand crisis situations, reduce uncertainty and maintain trust in authorities (Boin et al., 2005, p. 559). Emotional factors, information overload, practical constraints and perceived responsibility all influence how residents interpret and act on preparedness information. This is further supported by website engagement data, which indicates limited public engagement with preparedness-related information despite its availability. While residents are expected to be proactive and self-sufficient, preparedness in practice remains uneven and often reactive. The interviews help explain this gap by highlighting how behavioural factors, information overload, perceived responsibility and practical constraints shape how preparedness information is interpreted and acted upon. In this way, the findings show that preparedness is not only a matter of access to information, but of how individuals understand, prioritise and apply that information in everyday life. Taken together, the interview findings reinforce that preparedness is not only a matter of information provision, but of how responsibility, capability and relevance are perceived and shaped in everyday life. This suggests that current preparedness governance may overestimate the role of information provision, while underestimating the importance of behavioural, social and contextual factors in shaping actual preparedness.

6. Discussion

This study examines how municipal crisis preparedness is communicated and how this aligns with residents' perceived preparedness and intended actions. By integrating findings from document analysis, survey data and interviews, the results point to a consistent and underlying pattern which is a structural mismatch between institutional expectations and residents' preparedness. Rather than viewing this gap as a failure of communication or individual responsibility, this study argues that it emerges from how preparedness is framed, interpreted and translated into practice across different levels.

A central finding of this study is the gap between awareness and action. A key insight from the document analysis is that preparedness is framed as a matter of shared responsibility, where residents are expected to act based on the information provided by the municipality. This reflects a pre-crisis communication logic in which information is assumed to enable preparedness by clarifying roles and expected behaviours (Coombs, 2019, p. 10-11). At the institutional level, preparedness is therefore treated as a relatively linear process in which information leads to awareness, which in turn leads to action. However, when this framing is compared with the survey findings, this assumption becomes increasingly problematic. The survey data show a clear gap between awareness and action, while many respondents report exposure to preparedness information, significantly fewer report taking concrete measures. This pattern is further reinforced in the interviews, where municipal officials highlight that preparedness is often perceived by residents as abstract, postponed or dependent on future circumstances rather than immediate action. This supports the patterns identified in the survey data. These findings challenge the implicit institutional assumption, primarily identified in the document analysis, that information provision is sufficient to generate preparedness. This assumption is also reflected in the interviews, although municipal officials themselves acknowledge limitations in relying primarily on information provision. Despite this, communication practices remain largely information-based, indicating a tension between institutional awareness and practice. Together, these findings support previous research demonstrating that preparedness behaviour is shaped by a combination of motivational, psychological and contextual factors rather than knowledge alone (Levac et al., 2012, p. 730).

This gap is further explained by differences in how risks are perceived. While institutional communication frames risks in general and strategic terms, residents interpret these risks through individual perceptions such as familiarity, perceived control and personal relevance (Slovic, 2000, p. 233-234). The empirical findings suggest that many risks, including power outages or war-related scenarios are acknowledged but not perceived as urgent or personally relevant. This demonstrates that the mismatch identified in the study is not simply a matter of insufficient communication, but rather a misalignment between how risks are communicated and how they are perceived. In this sense, preparedness communication may be technically accurate yet socially ineffective.

Another important finding emerging from the results and analysis is the role of infrastructure dependence. The document analysis highlights structural vulnerabilities linked to interconnected systems such as electricity, communication and supply chains. However, both survey and interview responses show that residents' intended actions often rely on the continued functioning of these systems. In scenarios involving disruptions, respondents frequently describe improvised or reactive responses rather than planned preparedness. This suggests that while institutional actors recognise systemic vulnerability, this understanding is not fully translated into individual preparedness practices. Instead, everyday reliance on infrastructure may make vulnerability less visible and reduce the perceived need for preparation, which aligns with findings on risk in modern societies (Kaneberg, 2018, p. 22-23).

Trust emerges as a particularly complex and multifaceted factor in shaping

preparedness. On the one hand, relatively high levels of trust in authorities are often considered essential for effective crisis communication. On the other hand, the findings suggest that this trust may reduce individual motivation to prepare, as responsibility is instead transferred to public institutions. This supports previous research suggesting that trust can both enable and constrain preparedness behaviour (Ning et al., 2021, p. 1). At the same time, the interviews show that municipal actors emphasise that residents are expected to manage independently during the initial phase of a crisis, since institutional resources and response capacity are limited. This reveals a mismatch between public expectations and institutional assumptions regarding responsibility and preparedness. Rather than creating preparedness, trust may therefore reinforce the gap between awareness and action, as residents rely on authorities while institutional actors at the same time expect residents to take the first steps in managing crises themselves.

From a governance perspective, the findings highlight limitations in current preparedness approaches. While preparedness communication is extensive and distributed through multiple channels, the findings suggest limited follow-up regarding how information is received, interpreted and translated into preparedness behaviour in practice. This indicates that current preparedness governance places strong emphasis on information provision, while placing less emphasis on evaluating whether communication efforts actually lead to engagement or behavioural change. Municipal preparedness communication largely follows a top-down and information-driven logic, where residents are positioned as receivers of information rather than active participants in preparedness processes. However, the empirical results suggest that this approach does not fully capture how preparedness is shaped in everyday life. Residents interpret preparedness through personal experience, social context and practical constraints, meaning that institutional messages are filtered through everyday conditions and priorities before they are translated into action. This aligns with research emphasising the importance of dialogue, participation and locally adapted communication strategies (Eriksson, 2024, p. 19-20). The gap identified in this study can therefore also be understood as a misalignment between institutional communication strategies and everyday practices.

By bringing together institutional and individual perspectives, this study shows that preparedness is a relational and multi-level process. Preparedness is not simply the outcome of planning or individual decision-making, but emerges through the interaction between communication, perception, trust and everyday conditions, as risk responses are shaped by interpretation and social context (Slovic, 2000, p. 233-234). This supports the argument that preparedness should not be understood as a linear process from information to action, but as a complex process shaped by multiple interacting factors. At the same time, the findings raise important questions about how preparedness is organised. Current approaches appear to assume that residents will act if provided with clear information, yet the results suggest that this assumption overlooks key behavioural and social dynamics. This indicates a need to move beyond information-based approaches and instead focus on how preparedness can be made meaningful, relevant and practical in everyday life. From this perspective, improving preparedness may require not only better communication, but also greater alignment between institutional expectations and residents' lived realities.

Since many respondents recognised the VMA, "Hesa Fredrik" warning signal but lacked knowledge about how to interpret or respond to different warning signals, the findings suggest a need for more practical and repetitive preparedness communication. One possible measure could be to expand the quarterly testing of the "Hesa Fredrik" signal by also communicating the meaning of different warning signals. This may strengthen residents' practical knowledge and reduce uncertainty during crises. The findings in the thesis further suggest a need for more systematic follow-up and evaluation of how preparedness communication is interpreted and acted upon in practice, rather than assuming that the provision of information itself leads to preparedness. Building on these

findings, the mismatch identified in this study can be understood as a broader structural challenge in how preparedness is understood and implemented. Rather than existing only at the level of communication or individual behaviour, the issue emerges as a broader relational issue between institutional frameworks, communication practices and everyday conditions. This suggests that responsibility is formally distributed but not always translated into practice, as residents are expected to act but are not fully supported in translating general preparedness guidance into concrete practices.

Taken together, these findings show that the main challenge does not lie in the absence of information, but in how preparedness is communicated, interpreted and translated into practice at the individual level. The findings further suggest that preparedness should not primarily be understood as an issue of information access, but as a relational and behavioural process shaped by institutional expectations, individual interpretations and everyday conditions.

7. Conclusion

This chapter summarises the main findings of the study, discusses the study's contributions and practical implications and outlines suggestions for future research.

7.1 Summary of Findings

This study examined how municipal crisis preparedness is communicated and how this aligns with residents' perceived preparedness and intended actions. By combining document analysis, survey data and interviews, the findings reveal a consistent mismatch between institutional expectations of preparedness and residents' perceived preparedness and intended actions in everyday life. The study demonstrates that preparedness cannot be understood as a linear process in which information automatically leads to action but rather as a complex and relational process shaped by communication, interpretation, trust, everyday constraints and social conditions. A central finding is the gap between awareness and action. Municipal preparedness communication largely assumes that residents will take responsibility and act if they are provided with clear and accessible information. However, while many respondents reported awareness of preparedness recommendations and risks, significantly fewer reported having taken concrete preparedness measures. Preparedness depends not only on access to information, but also on how risks are perceived, interpreted and prioritised in everyday life. Residents often described preparedness as abstract, postponed or connected to future circumstances rather than immediate action, indicating that awareness alone does not necessarily translate into preparedness behaviour (Levac et al., 2012, p. 730).

The study further shows that preparedness is strongly influenced by individual perceptions of risk and vulnerability. While institutional communication frames risks in strategic and general terms, residents interpret risks through personal relevance, familiarity and perceived control (Slovic, 2000, p. 233-234). Several risks acknowledged in municipal communication, including power outages and war-related scenarios, were not perceived as sufficiently urgent to motivate preparation. This suggests that preparedness communication may be formally clear while still having limited practical impact if residents do not perceive the risks as relevant to their own lives. Another important finding concerns dependence on infrastructure and public systems. Although municipal documents highlight vulnerabilities connected to electricity, communication systems and supply chains, many residents' intended responses still relied on the continued functioning of these systems. In crisis scenarios, respondents frequently described reactive or improvised solutions rather than planned preparedness measures. The findings therefore indicate that institutional understandings of systemic vulnerability are not fully reflected in individual preparedness practices, partly because critical infrastructures remain largely invisible in everyday life until disruptions occur.

Trust also emerged as a complex factor in shaping preparedness. High levels of trust in authorities appeared to contribute to confidence in institutional crisis management, but at the same time reduced the perceived need for individual preparedness among some residents (Chen et al., 2019, p. 8). At the institutional level however, municipal actors emphasised that residents are expected to manage independently during the initial phase of a crisis due to limited institutional resources. The findings therefore reveal tensions between institutional expectations of self-preparedness and residents' reliance on institutional crisis management. From a governance perspective, the study identifies limitations in current preparedness approaches. Municipal preparedness communication largely follows a top-down and information-driven logic in which residents are positioned primarily as receivers of information (Albrechts & Balducci, 2013, p. 18 & 24). At the same time, the findings suggest limited evaluation of how preparedness communication is interpreted, understood and translated into preparedness practices. The study therefore indicates that current preparedness governance places stronger emphasis on distributing information than

on evaluating whether communication efforts actually lead to behavioural change or engagement. Taken together, the findings suggest that the main challenge in preparedness does not primarily concern lack of information, but rather how preparedness is communicated, interpreted and integrated into everyday life. The tension identified in this study can therefore be understood as a broader structural and relational issue between institutional frameworks and residents' lived realities. Preparedness emerges not simply as an issue of individual responsibility or institutional planning, but as a process shaped by the interaction between communication practices, social context, trust, risk perception and everyday conditions.

7.2 Contributions to the Field

This study contributes to research on crisis and war preparedness as well as strategic planning by linking municipal preparedness planning and communication with residents' perceptions and intended actions within a single empirical context. While previous research has examined these aspects separately, this study provides an integrated analysis of how preparedness is translated from planning into practice. The findings highlight the importance of understanding preparedness as a multi-level and relational process, shaped by the interaction between institutional communication and individual interpretation. By applying crisis and risk communication and risk perception theory, the study also contributes to a deeper understanding of why preparedness communication does not always lead to behavioural change.

In addition, the study provides an empirical contribution by examining these dynamics within the context of a Swedish municipality. By focusing on Norrköping, the study offers context-specific insights that may be relevant for similar municipalities facing comparable challenges related to infrastructure dependence, communication and public preparedness. The findings can therefore serve as a starting point for municipalities to reflect on and test different approaches to preparedness communication and engagement. Finally, the study contributes by identifying and making visible how institutional intentions do not always align with residents' preparedness. Recognising these differences is a necessary first step toward addressing it, as it highlights the limitations of current approaches and creates a foundation for developing more effective and context-specific preparedness strategies.

7.3 Practical Implications

The findings suggest that municipalities need to move beyond general information approaches and instead focus on more action-oriented communication strategies. For example, municipalities could move beyond written information by offering step-by-step guidance tailored to specific crisis scenarios, as well as organising local workshops or community-based preparedness activities. Follow-up methods such as surveys could also be used to better understand residents' preparedness over time and to identify which communication approaches are most effective in translating awareness into preparedness behaviour. In addition, municipalities could expand preparedness communication into everyday settings, such as workplaces and experiment with more personalised and tailored communication approaches to increase relevance and engagement. These approaches respond directly to the identified gap between awareness and action by making preparedness more concrete, locally relevant and embedded in everyday life. The findings also suggest that preparedness communication may need to communicate individual responsibility and limited institutional response capacity more explicitly. While municipal communication emphasises that residents are expected to manage independently during the initial phase of a crisis, many respondents still appeared to assume that support from authorities would be immediately available. This indicates a need for communication that more clearly explains that institutional assistance may be delayed during larger crises and that residents may need to manage independently for several days before support becomes available. Communicating these practical conditions more explicitly may increase the perceived urgency and personal relevance of preparedness. Finally, preparedness planning may benefit from a greater focus

on everyday conditions, acknowledging that individuals' ability to prepare is shaped by time, resources and other priorities in daily life.

7.4 Suggestions for Future Research

This study is based on a single municipal case and focuses on perceived preparedness and intended actions rather than actual behaviour in real crisis situations. Future research could expand this perspective by conducting comparative studies across municipalities or examining preparedness in different socio-economic or cultural contexts. Further research could also explore how preparedness develops over time and how different communication strategies influence behaviour in practice. In addition, there is a need for studies that examine how institutional and individual preparedness can be more effectively integrated, particularly in relation to participation, trust and behavioural change.

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